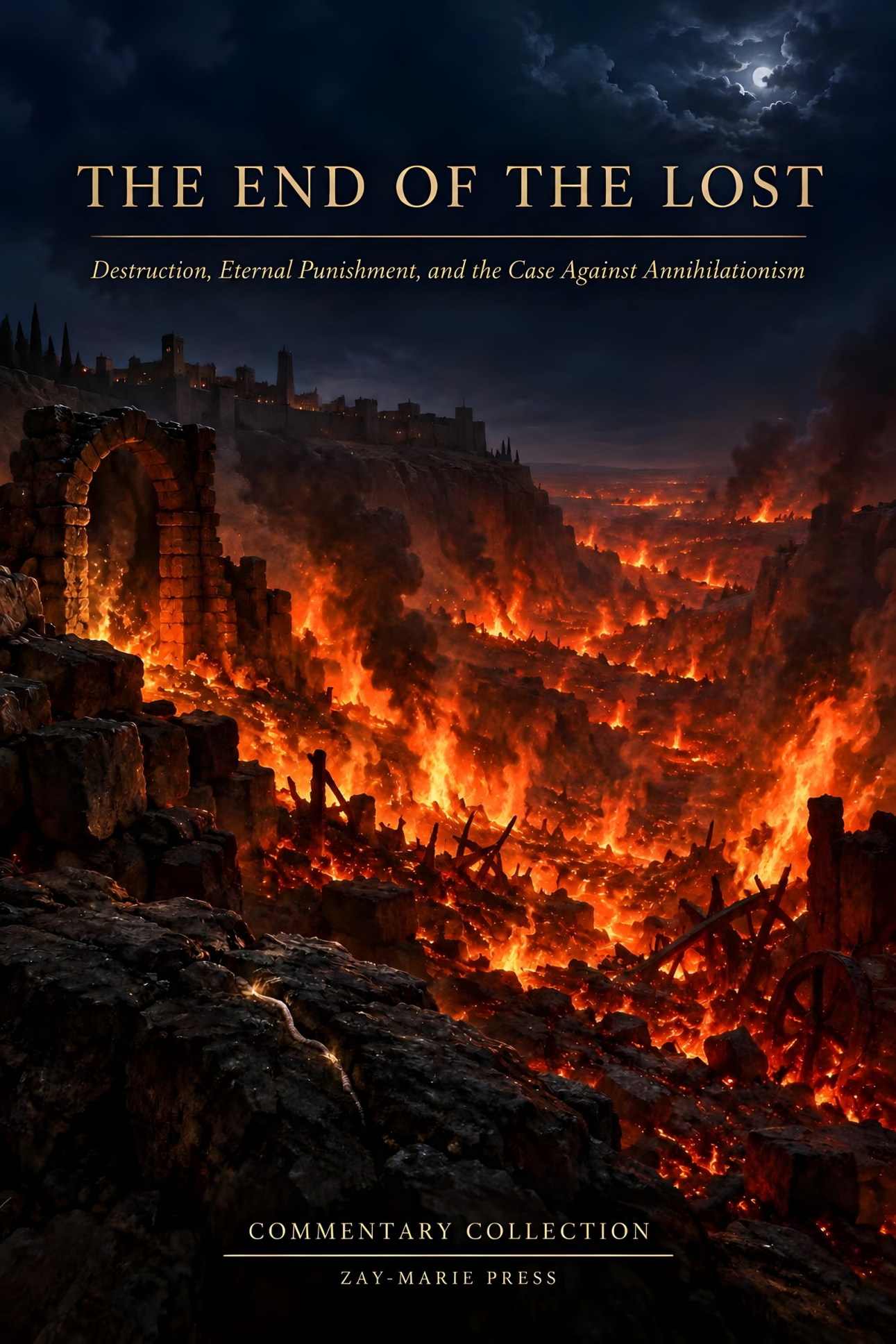
THE END OF THE LOST

Destruction, Eternal Punishment, and the Case Against Annihilationism



COMMENTARY COLLECTION

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1. Preface: The Question and the Position

This volume argues a position. It does not gather what churches say about the end of the lost and leave the reader to choose. It says what the author believes Scripture reveals, it sets the verses in the order they stand, and it answers the strongest objections from named modern writers, so that a reader who disagrees knows where the disagreement lies.

The question is old and it is asked in earnest. Three answers are given to it among those who hold that Scripture is the word of God. One holds that the lost are punished without end and are conscious in it. One holds that the lost are destroyed, and that destruction means they cease to exist, either at death or after a period of punishment. This second view goes by the names annihilationism and conditional immortality, and it is held today by a number of evangelical writers who are careful with the text. A third holds that all will at last be reconciled. This volume takes up the first two. It does not take up the third.

The position is this. The words Scripture uses for the end of the lost are not one word, and none of them settles the question by itself. Death, destruction, perishing, punishment, torment, exclusion, the second death and judgment each stand in their own passage with their own audience, and each has to be read there. A word that sometimes describes a thing coming to an end also describes, in other verses, a thing that remains in being and is ruined. Read cumulatively and each in its place, the passages that speak of final judgment tell of a punishment that cannot be reversed and does not end, and where the text says so, of an experience that continues. They do not require that the lost cease to exist.

Three things about the method. First, the King James Version is the volume's base English text, and every Scripture quotation is checked word for word against it. Where lexical or grammatical questions affect the argument, the relevant Hebrew or Greek wording is examined without replacing the passage's context with a word-study argument. Second, each chapter opens with a claim, reads its passages in order, and closes with a short table and a list of what the volume takes from the passages, so that the reader can see what has been argued and test it. Third, where a modern writer is named, the volume says what that writer holds, in its own words, and gives the writer's words only where it has read them in a free full text.

The volume does not take up everything its neighbours argue. Questions concerning the distinct courts of Scripture are treated fully in Volume 5 of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series, Separate Courts, and in Studies 31, 49 and 68. This volume does not reproduce that complete architecture, but chapter 8 examines the great white throne to the extent necessary to identify the company under judgment and interpret the lake of fire and the second death. The words for the unseen world and the lake of fire, reported as written, belong to Study 79, which takes no position and is not changed by this volume. The account in Luke 16 belongs to Parable Study 24, and the Lamb and the foundation of the world to Study 80. On those matters this volume cites the places and does not repeat them.

One boundary runs through the volume. The passages are read in the settings in which they stand. The Lord's words in the Gospels were spoken to Israel in His

Kingdom ministry, and the visions of Revelation name the audience they were sent to. Neither is carried over to the Body of Christ, and nothing in this volume is a warning to the Body or a statement about its standing. What those passages reveal about the fate of the wicked is the evidence the volume uses. It distinguishes that testimony from any application to the Body.

The Thesis

Destruction language in Scripture does not by itself establish that the lost cease to exist. Its meaning is fixed by context, and the words for death, destruction, punishment, torment, exclusion, the second death and judgment are not one word. Taken together, each in its own setting, the passages on final judgment establish a punishment that is irreversible and enduring, and where the text says so, a continuing experience of it. They do not require cessation of existence. No single Greek word and no single proof text carries the case, and the volume does not rest it on one.

The thesis in five statements.

Statement	What it says	Where it is argued
1	The words for destruction and perishing describe an ending in some verses and a ruined condition of something that remains in others. The word alone does not decide.	Chapters 2 and 3
2	Where the Lord speaks of the power to destroy soul and body in hell, the text states a power, in a mission to Israel, and does not state an outcome.	Chapter 4
3	Everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord is read from its context as an irreversible judicial penalty; the preposition may name exclusion or source, and the verse does not by itself state continuing experience.	Chapter 5
4	The same word for everlasting is set on the life and on the punishment in one verse, and the passages that follow describe a fire and a worm that do not end.	Chapters 6 and 7
5	In Revelation the worshippers of the beast are tormented and have no rest day nor night, the plural statement of torment at 20:10 takes in the beast and the false prophet cast in a thousand years before, and the second death is described by what the lake contains and does.	Chapter 8

A reader may test the thesis in one move. Take any verse in which a word of destruction stands, and ask three questions of it: who is addressed, what has just been said, and what does the verse say follows. The volume holds that the answers decide the meaning and that the word alone does not. If a passage can be produced in which the context itself states that the person ceases to be, the thesis is tested at

that point, and the volume says in chapter 9 which passages come nearest to that and why it reads them as it does.

2. How the Case Is Argued

Claim: the question of the end of the lost cannot be settled by choosing a word and giving it one meaning. It is settled, if it is settled, by reading each passage in its own setting and letting the settings add up. This chapter fixes the terms, the settings and the standard of proof before any passage is argued.

2.1 What the two positions claim

The two positions differ on one point. Both hold that the wicked will be judged, that the judgment is just, and that it is final. Both hold that the Lord Jesus bore sin and that salvation is His gift. They differ on what the final judgment is. On the first view the punishment of the lost is without end and is experienced. On the second view the punishment is real and may be painful, but it ends in the cessation of the person, and the word eternal describes a result that lasts for ever, not an experience that goes on. The second view rests on a good deal of Scripture and it is stated by its defenders as an exegetical conclusion, not as a way of softening the doctrine. The volume treats it so.

Two cautions follow. The first is that an argument against the second view must not be an argument from feeling. That the idea is hard to bear is no reason to deny it, and that the alternative is gentler is no reason to accept it. The second is that agreement on the earlier points should be said aloud. A writer who holds that the lost cease to exist is not thereby a denier of judgment, and a reader who holds the first view should be able to say what the writer holds before answering it.

2.2 Seven terms kept apart

The passages use a number of words for what happens to the lost. They are often gathered under one heading as if they said one thing. The volume keeps seven of them apart, and asks of each passage which of the seven it uses and what it states there.

The seven terms and what each is asked.

Term	Where it stands in Scripture	What the volume asks of it
Death	Genesis 2:17; Ezekiel 18:4; Luke 15:24; Ephesians 2:1	Does the passage describe an ending of life, or a condition of a living person?
Destruction, perishing	Matthew 10:28; Philippians 3:19; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Does the verse state that the thing ceases, or that it is ruined, lost or wasted?
Punishment	Matthew 25:46; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Does the punishment last, and how does the passage say it lasts?

Term	Where it stands in Scripture	What the volume asks of it
Torment	Revelation 14:10, 11; 20:10	Does the passage describe an experience, and does it say the experience has an end?
Exclusion	Matthew 7:23; 25:10–12; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Is the condition described as lasting, and from what are the persons excluded?
The second death	Revelation 20:14; 21:8	What is it called, and what does the passage say it contains?
Judgment	Hebrews 6:2; Revelation 20:11–15	What is the judgment said to be, and what follows it?

The table is a list of questions, not a list of answers. Some of the passages named in it are not argued until later chapters, and some are cited and not argued at all. The point is that a verse using the second term is not read as if it used the sixth.

2.3 The setting is fixed first

A passage is read in the setting in which it was spoken or written. The settings differ, and the differences bear on what a passage can be made to say. Israel's law and prophets speak to Israel about Israel and the nations round her. The Lord's words in the Gospels were spoken to Israel in His Kingdom ministry: He sent the Twelve "to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" and commanded them, "as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 10:6, 7). The letters of Paul are written to assemblies and to individuals, and their words on the end of the wicked stand in the course of an argument addressed to them. The letters that name their own readers are read for what they name. Revelation names its audience at the outset, and its visions are read as visions of events still to come.

The volume does not claim that every passage in every setting says the same thing about the lost. It claims that the settings, taken together, give a consistent account, and it tests the claim by reading each passage where it stands. A passage spoken to Israel is not treated as a command to the Body of Christ, and a passage written to an assembly is not treated as a word to Israel. What each passage reveals about the fate of the wicked is the evidence, and the audience is kept in view while it is gathered.

2.4 No single word, no single proof text

The case is cumulative. It does not rest on the Greek word for destroy, or on the word for everlasting, or on the smoke that goes up in Revelation 14, or on the worm of Mark 9. The volume does not expect any one of these to bear the weight of the question, and the reader should not be asked to believe that it does. Where the other side makes a fair point about a word, the volume says so. The point may be that destruction, in some verses, describes a thing coming to an end. It may be that everlasting, in some verses, describes a result. It may be that a fire which is not quenched does not by itself show that what is cast into it continues to burn. These are conceded where they are true, and the volume then asks what the rest of the passage and the passages beside it add.

2.5 Three marks of evidence

Each conclusion in the chapters that follow is marked as one of three kinds. A conclusion is Stated where the verse says it in so many words. It is shown by the context where the verse does not say it but the verses around it do, or the passage it quotes does. It is Inferred where the volume draws it by reasoning from what is stated and shown. A reader who accepts the first and the second and doubts the third knows exactly what he doubts. The volume holds that the case needs all three, and that it is weakest where it is inferred. It says so at those points.

How the argument is built.

Step	What is done	Chapters
Words	The words of destruction and death are shown to be used in more than one way, and the word alone is not taken to decide	2 and 3
Texts	The passages most often cited on either side are read in their own settings, in order	4 to 8
Objections	Named modern writers on both sides are stated in their own best form and answered from Scripture	9
Conclusion	What the cumulative reading shows is stated, with what it leaves unsaid	Conclusion

What the volume takes from this chapter

- The two positions agree that the wicked are judged and differ on whether the lost cease to exist; the volume treats the second as an exegetical conclusion.
- Seven terms are kept apart, and each passage is asked which of them it uses.
- Each passage is read in the setting in which it stands, and nothing said to Israel is carried to the Body of Christ.
- The case is cumulative; no single word or proof text carries it, and fair lexical points on the other side are conceded.
- Each conclusion is marked Stated, shown by the context, or Inferred.

3. Death, Destruction and Perishing in Their Own Contexts

Claim: the words most often cited for the end of the lost are used in Scripture of things that cease and of things that remain. The word alone does not decide which is meant. This chapter concedes what is true on the other side, shows the second use, and states what follows and what does not.

3.1 Where the words describe an ending

The words of destruction and death sometimes describe an end, and the volume says so first. Of the flood the record says, “All in whose nostrils was the breath of life, of all that was in the dry land, died” (Genesis 7:22), and in the next verse, “every living substance was destroyed which was upon the face of the ground” (Genesis 7:23).

Destroyed and died stand side by side, and the destroying is the dying. When Nebuchadnezzar was angry with the wise men, he “commanded to destroy all the wise men of Babylon” (Daniel 2:12), and the destroying is killing. When the Pharisees “held a council against him, how they might destroy him” (Matthew 12:14), the word is again the word for taking life. Of the sons of Korah’s company the record is that “they perished from among the congregation” (Numbers 16:33) after the earth closed upon them.

These are plain, and an annihilationist is right to cite them. Where a verse tells of a person put to death, destroy and perish describe the death. The volume does not deny it. The question is whether that is the only use of the words, and whether a verse in which they stand beside a judgment after death must be read as these are.

Where destruction and perishing describe death.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Genesis 7:22, 23	All in whose nostrils was the breath of life, of all that was in the dry land, died. And every living substance was destroyed which was upon the face of the ground, both man, and cattle, and the creeping things, and the fowl of the heaven; and they were destroyed from the earth: and Noah only remained alive, and they that were with him in the ark.	Died and destroyed describe the same event, the end of life on the ground.
Daniel 2:12	For this cause the king was angry and very furious, and commanded to destroy all the wise men of Babylon.	The command to destroy is a command to kill.
Matthew 12:14	Then the Pharisees went out, and held a council against him, how they might destroy him.	To destroy him is to put him to death.
Numbers 16:33	They, and all that appertained to them, went down alive into the pit, and the earth closed upon them: and they perished from among the congregation.	They perished from among the congregation, as the earth closed upon them.

3.2 Where the person is lost and remains

The same family of words is used in the Gospels of persons who are not dead and who are not destroyed in the sense just seen. The Lord sends the Twelve “to the lost sheep of the house of Israel” (Matthew 10:6). The sheep is Israel, and Israel is alive. In the parable the shepherd, “having an hundred sheep, if he lose one of them, doth not leave the ninety and nine in the wilderness, and go after that which is lost, until he find it” (Luke 15:4). The sheep that is lost is a sheep in the wilderness, and when it is found the shepherd says, “I have found my sheep which was lost” (Luke 15:6). The psalmist says of himself, “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek thy servant” (Psalm 119:176), and he is the one speaking.

The prodigal is spoken of in the same way. The father says, “this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found” (Luke 15:24), and the elder brother is told, “this thy brother was dead, and is alive again; and was lost, and is found” (Luke 15:32). The son was dead and lost while he lived, and the father’s speech is not about a corpse. The Lord gives the purpose of His coming in the same terms: “the Son of man is come to save that which was lost” (Matthew 18:11), and “to seek and to save that which was lost” (Luke 19:10). That which is lost is sought and found. It has not ceased to be.

The point is limited. These verses are about persons in this life, and the parables of Luke 15 are Parable Study territory. They show that the word for lost and perishing is used of a living person in a condition of ruin or distance, and they do not say what becomes of the persons beyond the judgment. The volume draws only the lexical conclusion: the word does not mean cease to be in every verse in which it stands.

3.3 Where the thing destroyed remains

The same is true of things. “Neither do men put new wine into old bottles: else the bottles break, and the wine runneth out, and the bottles perish: but they put new wine into new bottles, and both are preserved” (Matthew 9:17). The bottles perish and the verb is set against being preserved. The skins are burst and useless, and they are there on the ground. In Mark 14 the disciples ask of the ointment, “Why was this waste of the ointment made?” (Mark 14:4), and Matthew puts it, “To what purpose is this waste?” (Matthew 26:8). The word is the noun of the same family, and the ointment was not annihilated. It was poured out.

Peter says that the world that then was “being overflowed with water, perished” (2 Peter 3:6). In the verse before he has said that the earth was “standing out of the water and in the water” (2 Peter 3:5), and in the verse after, the heavens and the earth “which are now” are reserved “unto fire against the day of judgment and perdition of ungodly men” (2 Peter 3:7). The ordered world of that time perished, and the earth remained under the water. The letter names its readers, and the volume reads it so; it is cited here for how the word is used, and the passage is argued by no one in this chapter.

Nations are spoken of in the same way. Pharaoh’s servants say to him, “knowest thou not yet that Egypt is destroyed?” (Exodus 10:7), and Egypt was standing. Of Moab the LORD says, “Moab shall be destroyed from being a people” (Jeremiah 48:42), and at the end of the chapter, “Yet will I bring again the captivity of Moab in the latter days” (Jeremiah 48:47). Moab is destroyed as a people and is afterwards brought back from captivity. Hosea says to Israel, “My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge” (Hosea 4:6), and they are still addressed as his people. Paul’s word for the discipline of the offender at Corinth is “the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus” (1 Corinthians 5:5). The destruction is of the flesh, and the spirit is saved.

Where what is destroyed or lost remains.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matthew 10:6	But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.	The lost sheep is Israel, who is alive and is sent to.
Luke 15:24	For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found. And they began to be merry.	Dead and lost are said of a son who is alive and speaking.
Matthew 9:17	Neither do men put new wine into old bottles: else the bottles break, and the wine runneth out, and the bottles perish: but they put new wine into new bottles, and both are preserved.	The bottles perish and are set against being preserved; they are ruined, not gone.
Exodus 10:7	And Pharaoh's servants said unto him, How long shall this man be a snare unto us? let the men go, that they may serve the LORD their God: knowest thou not yet that Egypt is destroyed?	Egypt is destroyed and is still there.
Jeremiah 48:42	And Moab shall be destroyed from being a people, because he hath magnified himself against the LORD.	Moab is destroyed from being a people, and later restored from captivity.
1 Corinthians 5:5	To deliver such an one unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.	Destruction of the flesh, with the spirit saved.

3.4 Death as a condition

The word for death is used in two ways too. In the garden the word is, “in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die” (Genesis 2:17), and the prophet writes, “the soul that sinneth, it shall die” (Ezekiel 18:4). An annihilationist reads these as the end of life, and the volume grants that they can be read so; Ezekiel 18:4 is among the strongest verses on that side, and it is answered in chapter 9. But the writers of the New Testament speak of death as a state of the living: “you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins” (Ephesians 2:1), and the father’s “was dead, and is alive again” of Luke 15:24 stands beside it. The letter to Ephesus is cited here for the use of the word, and the setting of its readers is not in question.

So death, like destruction, is not one thing in the text. It may be the end of life, and it may be the condition of one who is alive and cut off. A verse that says the wages of sin is death does not say which, and the volume does not read it as if it did.

3.5 What follows, and what does not

Three statements follow, and the volume marks them. It is Stated that destroy, perish, lost and death are used in Scripture of things that cease and of things that remain. It

is shown by the context that the second use is not rare: it occurs in the Gospels, the law, the prophets and the letters, of persons, nations and things. It is Inferred that a destruction verse set beside a judgment after death cannot be read from the word alone, and that the passage and its neighbours have to decide.

Three statements do not follow. It does not follow that the lost do not cease to exist; the chapter has only cleared the ground. It does not follow that the destruction verses are all about ruin; where a verse says a person was put to death, it says so, and the volume does not blur that. And it does not follow that the words of the other side are weak. Where an annihilationist says that destroy often means kill, he is right, and the cases above are the evidence.

Two neighbours are cited and not repeated. The oracles against the nations, among them Moab, are read in Volume 3 of The Prophets Series, The Nations Judged, with their own question. The Lord's mission to the lost sheep of the house of Israel is read in Volume 2 of the Gospel Commentary Series, The Lord's Ministry to Israel. This chapter takes from them only the use of the words.

The two uses of the words, side by side.

Word	Where it describes an end	Where the thing remains
Destroy	Genesis 7:23; Daniel 2:12; Matthew 12:14	Exodus 10:7; Jeremiah 48:42; 1 Corinthians 5:5
Perish	Numbers 16:33	Matthew 9:17; 2 Peter 3:6
Lost	Not used of the end of a living person in these passages	Matthew 10:6; Luke 15:4, 6, 24, 32; Luke 19:10
Death	Genesis 7:22; Genesis 2:17 on one reading	Luke 15:24; Ephesians 2:1

What the volume takes from the passages

- Destroy and perish describe death in Genesis 7, Daniel 2, Matthew 12 and Numbers 16, and the volume grants it.
- The same words are used of persons who are lost and remain, of things ruined and still there, and of nations destroyed as a people and later restored.
- Death is used of the end of life and of the condition of one who is alive and cut off.
- The word alone does not decide; the passage and its neighbours have to, which is the work of the chapters that follow.

4. Matthew 10:28 and Philippians 3:19

Claim: the two verses most often brought forward for the destruction of the lost state a power and an outcome, and neither states the manner or the length of that outcome. This chapter reads them in their own settings, concedes what the other side rightly takes from them, and says what the volume does and does not build on them.

4.1 The setting of Matthew 10

The Lord's words in Matthew 10:28 are spoken in a commission. He has called the Twelve and sent them out with an instruction that fixes their ground: "Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (Matthew 10:5, 6). Their message is "The kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 10:7), and their works are to "Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out devils" (Matthew 10:8). The chapter then turns to what will befall them. They are sent "as sheep in the midst of wolves" (Matthew 10:16), they will be delivered up to councils and scourged in synagogues, brought before governors and kings, and hated of all men for the Lord's name's sake. They are told, "Ye shall not have gone over the cities of Israel, till the Son of man be come" (Matthew 10:23).

Everything in the chapter so far is addressed to Israel's messengers in Israel's cities, in the Kingdom ministry, and the volume reads the verse that follows in that setting. It is a witness to what the Lord says of the fate of the wicked. It is not a word to the Body of Christ and it is not applied to it. The chapter also speaks of the day of judgment in its own terms: of a city that will not receive the Twelve the Lord says, "It shall be more tolerable for the land of Sodom and Gomorrha in the day of judgment, than for that city" (Matthew 10:15). A judgment with degrees is already in view before the verse on destroying soul and body is reached.

4.2 What Matthew 10:28 states

The verse reads, "And fear not them which kill the body, but are not able to kill the soul: but rather fear him which is able to destroy both soul and body in hell" (Matthew 10:28). It is built on a contrast. The first party can kill the body and can do no more. The second party is able to destroy both soul and body in hell, and for that reason is to be feared. The persecutors named in the chapter are the first party. The second is God. The sentence is a ground for courage: the Twelve are not to be afraid of what men can do, because what God can do is greater, and He is the one to whom they answer.

The two parties of Matthew 10:28 and the parallel in Luke 12.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matthew 10:28	And fear not them which kill the body, but are not able to kill the soul: but rather fear him which is able to destroy both soul and body in hell.	The first party kills the body and is not able to kill the soul; the second is able to destroy both soul and body in hell.
Luke 12:4	And I say unto you my friends, Be not afraid of them that kill the body, and after that have no more that they can do.	The first party kills the body and after that has no more that they can do.
Luke 12:5	But I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear: Fear him, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear him.	The one to be feared, after he hath killed, hath power to cast into hell.

Three things are stated. The first is a power: the verse says “able”. It does not say that this power is exercised in a given case, or on whom. The second is that the object of the power is “both soul and body”, which is more than the persecutors can touch. The third is the place: “in hell”, the word the Gospels use for the valley of Hinnom and the judgment it stands for. What the verse does not state is what the destroying consists of, how long it lasts, and whether the one destroyed continues. Those are not in the sentence.

4.3 The parallel in Luke 12

Luke records the same teaching in another setting. The Lord is speaking “unto his disciples first of all” while an innumerable multitude is gathered, and He begins, “Beware ye of the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy” (Luke 12:1). The same ground is given for courage: “there is nothing covered, that shall not be revealed” (Luke 12:2). Then comes the saying: “Be not afraid of them that kill the body, and after that have no more that they can do” (Luke 12:4), followed by “Fear him, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear him” (Luke 12:5).

The two accounts give the same two parties and the same two fears, in different words. Where Matthew says that God is able to destroy soul and body in hell, Luke says that He, after He hath killed, hath power to cast into hell. The volume reads the second as shedding light on the first. In Luke the power is stated in two steps, a killing and then a casting, and the casting is into hell. In Matthew the destroying is “in hell”. The place is the same and the power is the same. The volume holds that this is shown by the context and not Stated: the Lord does not say in either place that the two sayings are one, and a reader who takes the Matthew verse alone is not wrong to ask what the destroying is. The parallel is the nearest answer the text gives, and it describes a casting, not a ceasing.

4.4 What the other side rightly takes from the verse

A writer who holds that the lost cease to exist reads the verse as the plainest statement of his case. God is able to destroy the soul. If the soul can be destroyed, it is not by nature beyond the reach of its Maker, and the ordinary idea that the soul cannot die is not found in this verse. The volume grants both points. Matthew 10:28 does not teach that the soul is indestructible, and nothing in this volume rests on the idea that it is. The verse also treats the soul and the body together as the object of the power, which is the opposite of the picture in which the body perishes and the soul goes on untouched.

The writer goes a step further and reads “destroy” as the act of ending the person, and “able” as a statement of what God will do. The first step is possible. The second is a conclusion the verse does not draw. A power is not an outcome, and the Lord in the same chapter speaks of degrees in the day of judgment, which is a statement about the condition of those judged and not only about their removal. The volume therefore does not say that Matthew 10:28 proves a continuing experience. It says that the verse states a power and a place, that Luke 12:5 describes the exercise of the power as a casting into hell, and that neither verse says what the person is afterwards.

4.5 The word destruction in other places

The noun that stands at the root of the question is used in the New Testament in more than one way, and the uses bear on what a reader may take from it. Of the

ointment poured on the Lord's head the disciples said, "To what purpose is this waste?" (Matthew 26:8), and another account records, "Why was this waste of the ointment made?" (Mark 14:4). The ointment was not annihilated; it was spent without profit, and the word names that. Of Simon the sorcerer Peter said, "Thy money perish with thee, because thou hast thought that the gift of God may be purchased with money" (Acts 8:20), where the perishing is the condemnation of a man who is standing there. The Lord says of the apostles He had kept, "none of them is lost, but the son of perdition" (John 17:12), and the loss named there is spoken of a living disciple. In the letter to the Romans the vessels of wrath are described as "fitted to destruction" and as having been endured "with much longsuffering" (Romans 9:22), and vessels that are endured are there to be endured.

These uses do not decide the sense of the word at Matthew 10:28. They show that the noun does not always mean an extinction. In a verse where a person is lost, wasted, condemned or fitted for ruin, the word names what has happened to him, and the question whether he continues is not answered by the word. The question has to be answered by the passage.

4.6 Philippians 3:19

The second verse comes from a letter. Paul writes to the saints at Philippi and gives them a pattern: "Brethren, be followers together of me, and mark them which walk so as ye have us for an ensample" (Philippians 3:17). He then speaks of others: "many walk, of whom I have told you often, and now tell you even weeping, that they are the enemies of the cross of Christ: Whose end is destruction, whose God is their belly, and whose glory is in their shame, who mind earthly things" (Philippians 3:18, 19). The contrast follows at once: "For our conversation is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Saviour, the Lord Jesus Christ: Who shall change our vile body, that it may be fashioned like unto his glorious body" (Philippians 3:20, 21).

The verse names an end and calls it destruction. It describes those whose end it is in four phrases, each of them a description of a way of life, and it sets them against the saints, whose end is a changed body and a Saviour from heaven. The word translated "end" is the outcome of a course, and the verse states that the outcome of the course it describes is destruction. Paul had already used the same noun in the same letter. Of the saints' adversaries he says that their courage is "an evident token of perdition, but to you of salvation, and that of God" (Philippians 1:28). In each place the word stands over against salvation, and in each place it names the opposite of being saved.

The verse is read as written. It states that the enemies of the cross have an end and that the end is destruction. It does not describe the destruction. It does not say that the person ceases, and it does not say that the person continues. Nor is it a warning to the saints at Philippi; the letter speaks of them as those whose conversation is in heaven, and the verse describes others. The volume draws from it only what it states, that Paul sets the end of the enemies of the cross against the end of the saints and calls the first destruction.

4.7 What the two verses leave open

The reader who has followed the chapter will see what has been done. Two verses that carry much of the weight in the conditionalist case have been read in their settings and given their full force: the soul can be destroyed by God, and the end of

the enemies of the cross is destruction. Neither has been made to say more than it says. The verse in Matthew states a power and a place and is paralleled by a verse that describes the exercise of the power as casting into hell. The verse in Philippians states an end and a name. Whether the destruction is a ceasing or a ruin that remains is not settled by either. It is settled, if it is settled, by the passages that go on to describe what follows the judgment, and the next chapters turn to them.

The two verses compared.

	Matthew 10:28	Philippians 3:19
Who speaks	The Lord, to the Twelve	Paul, to the saints at Philippi
Of whom	The One who is able to destroy; the persecutors are the other party	The enemies of the cross of Christ
What is stated	A power: able to destroy soul and body in hell	An end: whose end is destruction
What is set against it	The persecutors, who kill the body and can do no more	The saints, whose conversation is in heaven
What is not stated	That the power is exercised; the manner; the length; whether the person continues	The manner; the length; whether the person continues
Setting	The Twelve's mission to Israel, in the Kingdom ministry	A letter to saints, with the enemies of the cross described as others

What the volume takes from the passages

- Matthew 10:28 is spoken to the Twelve on their mission to Israel; it is a witness to the fate of the wicked and is not applied to the Body.
- The verse states a power of God and a place, and treats the soul and the body as the object of the power; it does not teach that the soul is indestructible.
- Luke 12:5 describes the same power as a casting into hell after the killing, and the volume holds this shown by the context.
- The noun for destruction is used of waste, of a condemned man, of a lost disciple and of vessels endured, so the word alone does not decide.
- Philippians 3:19 states an end and calls it destruction, setting it against the saints' end; it does not describe the manner or the length.
- Neither verse is made to prove a continuing experience, and neither is made to prove a ceasing.

5. 2 Thessalonians 1:7–10

Claim: Paul describes an everlasting judicial destruction associated with the presence and glorious power of the Lord. The immediate context permits an exclusion reading, but the preposition may also identify the Lord's presence as the source of the judgment. The verse establishes an irreversible penalty; it does not by itself establish

continuing conscious experience. The sentence is judicial and sets the penalty against a rest given to the saints.

5.1 The setting

The letter is written “unto the church of the Thessalonians in God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ” (2 Thessalonians 1:1). Its readers are under pressure. Paul thanks God for their faith and tells them that he glories in them “in the churches of God for your patience and faith in all your persecutions and tribulations that ye endure” (2 Thessalonians 1:4). He then explains what their endurance shows: “Which is a manifest token of the righteous judgment of God, that ye may be counted worthy of the kingdom of God, for which ye also suffer” (2 Thessalonians 1:5). The sentence that holds the verses in question begins in the next verse, and what it says is bound up with that setting. It is a word of comfort to persecuted saints about the justice of God toward those who persecute them.

The passage is read as written. It tells the saints at Thessalonica what will be done to those who trouble them, and it is not a warning addressed to the Body of Christ about its own standing. Its subject is the end of persecutors and of those who know not God, and the volume treats it as a witness to that end.

5.2 One sentence

Verses 6 to 10 are a single sentence in the King James Version, and its parts have to be read together. The sentence says that “it is a righteous thing with God to recompense tribulation to them that trouble you”, and that He will give rest to the troubled “when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels, In flaming fire taking vengeance on them that know not God, and that obey not the gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ: Who shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord, and from the glory of his power; When he shall come to be glorified in his saints, and to be admired in all them that believe” (2 Thessalonians 1:6–10).

The parts of the sentence.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2 Thessalonians 1:6	Seeing it is a righteous thing with God to recompense tribulation to them that trouble you;	The ground: it is a righteous thing with God to recompense tribulation to those who trouble the saints.
2 Thessalonians 1:7	And to you who are troubled rest with us, when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels,	The saints who are troubled are given rest with Paul, when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with His mighty angels.
2 Thessalonians 1:8	In flaming fire taking vengeance on them that know not God, and that obey not the gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ:	The Lord comes in flaming fire, taking vengeance on those who know not God and obey not the gospel.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2 Thessalonians 1:9	Who shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord, and from the glory of his power;	These shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power.
2 Thessalonians 1:10	When he shall come to be glorified in his saints, and to be admired in all them that believe (because our testimony among you was believed) in that day.	The same coming is the Lord glorified in His saints and admired in all them that believe.

The vocabulary is the vocabulary of a court. There is a “righteous judgment” (verse 5), a “recompense” (verse 6), a “vengeance” taken (verse 8) and a punishment (verse 9). The verb in verse 9 is the verb of a penalty paid: those named will be punished, that is, will pay the penalty. The destruction is what the penalty is. This governs how it is read. A penalty is exacted by a judge. It is a thing that is done to persons for what they have done, and the sentence says in what it consists and from what the persons are removed.

5.3 What “destruction” does in this sentence

The noun used here is not the one of Matthew 10:28 and Philippians 3:19. It is the word that Paul uses in the first letter, “sudden destruction cometh upon them, as travail upon a woman with child; and they shall not escape” (1 Thessalonians 5:3), and in the letter to Timothy of lusts “which drown men in destruction and perdition” (1 Timothy 6:9). It is also the word of the sentence on the offender at Corinth, who is to be delivered “unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus” (1 Corinthians 5:5). In that last verse the person who is destroyed in the flesh is the same person whose spirit is saved, and he is alive when the sentence is passed and alive when it is carried out. The word there names a heavy loss inflicted on a living man, and the man does not cease.

The point is the same as in chapter 3. The noun can name an ending, as when a thing is broken beyond use, and it can name a ruin inflicted on one who goes on. Nothing in the word itself says which is meant at 2 Thessalonians 1:9, and the writer who holds that the lost cease to exist is right that the word is available to his reading. The sentence has to be read for what it adds.

5.4 What the sentence adds

It adds three things. The first is the adjective. The destruction is “everlasting”. The volume takes up the word at length in chapter 6 and concedes there that it can describe a result as well as a process. Here it is enough to say that the sentence does not describe a destruction that is accomplished and is over. A penalty that is called everlasting is a penalty whose effect does not end and is not reversed. That much is Stated.

The second is the contrast with the saints. The same sentence says that the saints will have “rest” when the Lord is revealed (verse 7), and that the Lord is “glorified in his saints” and “admired in all them that believe” at His coming (verse 10). The persons

who are punished are described by what they are away from: “from the presence of the Lord, and from the glory of his power” (verse 9). The presence and the glory are the place where the saints are given rest and the Lord is admired. The sentence sets the two fates side by side, and the second is, on the exclusion reading, the loss of what the first receives. That is shown by the context, with the caution of section 5.5 that the preposition may also name the source of the judgment.

The third is the Lord’s own use of the same idea. In the Gospels the lost are not only those who are removed but those who are shut out. To those who plead their works the Lord says, “I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity” (Matthew 7:23). Of the virgins who came late it is said that “the door was shut” and the answer was “I know you not” (Matthew 25:10, 12). In Luke the master of the house “hath shut to the door”, those outside stand and knock, and the answer is “depart from me, all ye workers of iniquity”, and there is “weeping and gnashing of teeth, when ye shall see Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, and all the prophets, in the kingdom of God, and you yourselves thrust out” (Luke 13:25–28). These passages are spoken to Israel in the Kingdom ministry and are not applied to the Body. They are used for what they reveal about the wicked: the condition they describe is a condition of exclusion, and in the last of them the persons shut out see what they are shut out from.

5.5 “From the presence of the Lord”

The clause in question reads “from the presence of the Lord, and from the glory of his power”. The preposition can be read in two ways. It can name the place from which the lost are removed, so that the penalty is a casting away from the Lord. It can name the source, so that the destruction comes forth from the Lord’s presence as the earth and the heaven “fled away” from the face of Him that sat on the throne (Revelation 20:11). The writer who holds that the lost cease to exist may take either reading and find his view in it, and the writer who holds that they continue may do the same. The volume does not rest the case on the preposition.

It rests on the setting, and the setting favours the first reading without requiring it. The sentence has been speaking of rest for the troubled saints, and of the Lord glorified in them. The persons it turns to have been described as those who “know not God” and “obey not the gospel” (2 Thessalonians 1:8). The penalty named for them is a destruction that does not end, from the presence of the One whom the saints are with. Read so, the verse describes an enduring exclusion; the setting permits this reading and does not require it. The wording of the clause has a likeness in the prophet’s picture of the day of the Lord, in which men go “into the holes of the rocks, and into the caves of the earth, for fear of the LORD, and for the glory of his majesty, when he ariseth to shake terribly the earth” (Isaiah 2:19). The volume notes the likeness of idea and does not claim that Paul is quoting.

The verse does not describe the experience of those excluded. It does not use the word torment, and the volume does not say that it states continuing consciousness. It states a penalty that is everlasting, a destruction, and an exclusion from the presence of the Lord. Whether the penalty includes the experience of being under it is a question for the passages that speak of it directly, and the volume turns to them in chapters 7 and 8. A reader who says that the verse is consistent with the annihilation of the persons has said what is true: it is consistent with it. The volume’s reply is that the verse is also consistent with the persons’ continuing, that it does not decide between the two, and that the verses which do decide are read in their places.

What is stated, shown and inferred in the passage.

Point	How the volume holds it	Mark
The penalty is everlasting	The adjective is set on the destruction	Stated
The sentence is judicial	Judgment, recompense, vengeance and punishment are the words used	Stated
The lost are set over against the saints	Rest and glory for the saints, penalty from the presence of the Lord for the lost	shown by the context
The penalty is irreversible, and the setting permits an exclusion reading	Read from the adjective, the judicial words and the Gospels' shut door; the preposition may also name source	Inferred
The persons continue to be	Not stated; argued from other passages, not from this one	Not claimed here
The persons cease to be	Not stated; the verse is consistent with it and does not require it	Not claimed here

What the volume takes from the passage

- The passage is addressed to a persecuted assembly and speaks of the end of those who trouble them and know not God; it is not a warning to the Body.
- Verses 6 to 10 are one judicial sentence, and the destruction is the penalty the Lord exacts.
- The noun for destruction is used elsewhere of a loss inflicted on a living man, so the word alone does not decide.
- The penalty is everlasting and is set against the rest and glory of the saints, which is the sentence's own contrast.
- The Gospels' shut door and the command to depart describe an exclusion in which the persons are said to see what they are shut out from.
- The verse establishes an irreversible penalty. The setting permits an exclusion reading, the preposition may also name the Lord's presence as the source of the judgment, and the verse does not state whether the persons continue to experience it.

6. "Eternal": Matthew 25:46, Daniel 12:2 and Jude 7

Claim: Scripture sets one adjective on both the life of the righteous and the punishment of the wicked, and sets it on the contempt of Daniel 12:2 and on the fire of Jude 7. The adjective can describe a result that lasts, and the volume says so. In these passages, read in their settings, the result that is said to last is one that persons go into, and the passages do not describe it as a thing completed and finished.

6.1 One word on both sides of one verse

The Lord ends His account of the judgment of the nations with a single sentence: “And these shall go away into everlasting punishment: but the righteous into life eternal” (Matthew 25:46). The King James Version renders the one adjective of the original by two English words, “everlasting” and “eternal”, for the sake of the sound. The adjective is the same on both sides of the colon. If the life is without end, the punishment is described by the same word. The reader is not asked to take it in a different sense in the second clause than in the first, and a reading that makes the life endless and the punishment a momentary act does so without a hint from the verse.

This is the strongest single support the volume takes from the verse, and it is not a proof taken alone. The writer on the other side answers that the adjective describes the quality or the result of what it qualifies. The life is of the age to come and it lasts, because the persons live it. The punishment is of the age to come and its result lasts, because the persons are gone. The reply is not an evasion. The New Testament speaks of “eternal redemption” (Hebrews 9:12), and the redemption is not a process still going on: it was obtained once, by the blood, and its result is for ever. It speaks of “eternal salvation” (Hebrews 5:9) and of “eternal judgment” (Hebrews 6:2), and in each the adjective states that the result does not lapse. The volume grants that the adjective has this use.

It grants it and asks what the verse says the persons do. The righteous go “into life eternal”, and the wicked “shall go away into everlasting punishment”. Both groups proceed to their assigned destinies, and the same adjective qualifies punishment and life. The parallel strongly establishes the permanence of both outcomes, though the verse alone does not explain how the punishment is experienced. The noun for punishment is used in only one other place in the New Testament, in the verse, “There is no fear in love; but perfect love casteth out fear: because fear hath torment” (1 John 4:18), where what it names is a thing felt by one who is afraid. The volume does not make this a lexical proof, and the noun alone does not settle the duration or the manner of the punishment. It notes that the one other place in which the noun stands is one in which the thing named is felt.

Where an adjective of age or duration is set on a result.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Hebrews 9:12	Neither by the blood of goats and calves, but by his own blood he entered in once into the holy place, having obtained eternal redemption for us.	Eternal redemption: the redemption was obtained once and its result does not lapse.
Hebrews 5:9	And being made perfect, he became the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey him;	Eternal salvation: the salvation is of Christ and is not temporary.
Hebrews 6:2	Of the doctrine of baptisms, and of laying on of hands, and of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment.	Eternal judgment: listed among the first principles; the sentence is not reversed.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matthew 25:46	And these shall go away into everlasting punishment: but the righteous into life eternal.	The same adjective on the punishment of the wicked and the life of the righteous; the persons go into each.

6.2 The setting of Matthew 25

The verse closes the Olivet Discourse, which the Lord spoke on the Mount of Olives to the disciples who asked Him privately, "what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?" (Matthew 24:3). The scene is the Son of man's coming "in his glory" (Matthew 25:31), when "before him shall be gathered all nations" (Matthew 25:32) and He divides them as a shepherd divides his sheep from the goats. The ground of the division is what they have done to "one of the least of these my brethren" (Matthew 25:40, 45), and the King's brethren are the people to whom the discourse was addressed. This is the setting of Israel's Kingdom, at the King's return, and it is the setting the volume holds to. The verse is a witness to the fate of the wicked in that judgment and is not applied to the Body of Christ. Who is judged where, and why the Scripture does not merge the courts, is the work of Volume 5 of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series, Volume 3 of the Gospel Commentary Series and Study 31, and it is not repeated here.

Within the setting, the King's words to the goats are the sentence the verse then names: "Depart from me, ye cursed, into everlasting fire, prepared for the devil and his angels" (Matthew 25:41). The fire is everlasting, it is a place into which persons go, and it was prepared for the devil and his angels. The words do not say that the persons in it are tormented or that they are consumed. They say that the fire is everlasting, and that the wicked share the destination prepared for the devil and his angels. The volume holds that what the Revelation says of the devil's place in the lake of fire is to be read beside this (Revelation 20:10), and it does that in chapter 8, not here.

6.3 Daniel 12:2

The prophet's word is spoken in the setting of Israel and her last trouble: "at that time shall Michael stand up, the great prince which standeth for the children of thy people: and there shall be a time of trouble, such as never was since there was a nation even to that same time: and at that time thy people shall be delivered, every one that shall be found written in the book" (Daniel 12:1). The next verse is the one the volume reads: "And many of them that sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt" (Daniel 12:2).

The adjective stands here too, and it stands on both sides again. There is "everlasting life" and there is "everlasting contempt". Both groups are said to awake. The second group does not awake to be ended; it awakes "to shame and everlasting contempt". The word for contempt is a word of abhorrence, and it is the same word that the prophet Isaiah uses at the end of his book: "they shall be an abhorring unto all flesh" (Isaiah 66:24). The two are the only places in the Old Testament where the word stands, and the volume reads them together in chapter 7. The point to be made here is that the verse describes a contempt that is everlasting, and a contempt is held by

someone toward someone. For the contempt to go on, the persons who are held in it must go on being what it is held against.

This is Inferred, not Stated, and the volume says so. A reader who holds that the persons cease can answer that the contempt is the memory in which they are held. That reading is not impossible. The volume holds that the verse says more naturally what it appears to say, that those who awake to shame awake to a lasting shame, and that it is stated in a verse where the same adjective is set on the life of the others. The verse does not bear the whole case, and it does not need to.

6.4 Jude 7

The third passage is the hardest for the volume's side and the volume takes it so. Jude writes "to them that are sanctified by God the Father, and preserved in Jesus Christ, and called" (Jude 1:1), and he warns of "certain men crept in unawares, who were before of old ordained to this condemnation" (Jude 1:4). He gives three examples of the judgment that follows. The Lord "afterward destroyed them that believed not" (Jude 1:5). The angels who left their own habitation are "reserved in everlasting chains under darkness unto the judgment of the great day" (Jude 1:6). And "Sodom and Gomorrha, and the cities about them in like manner, giving themselves over to fornication, and going after strange flesh, are set forth for an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire" (Jude 1:7).

The annihilationist reading of the last example is a strong one. The cities of the plain are not burning today. Peter says that God turned "the cities of Sodom and Gomorrha into ashes", "making them an ensample unto those that after should live ungodly" (2 Peter 2:6). The fire that destroyed them was God's, and it is called eternal because its result is permanent: the cities are gone and will not return. On this reading "eternal fire" in Jude 7 is the same kind of statement as "eternal redemption", a statement about a result, and the cities are the example of what that fire does. The volume grants all of it. If Jude 7 stood alone it would be a verse on which the two sides could differ and neither could say that the verse decides.

It does not stand alone. The cities are "set forth for an example", and an example is an example of something other than itself, of the vengeance of eternal fire that those who follow the same course will suffer. The verse goes on, in the same sentence, to say that the cities are "suffering" it, in the words of the King James Version, and the persons who gave themselves over are the ones named as the subject of the suffering. The preceding verse speaks of angels held "in everlasting chains under darkness", and a verse later the false teachers are "wandering stars, to whom is reserved the blackness of darkness for ever" (Jude 1:13). A reader who says that Jude's examples are all of results and not of states has to give an account of chains, darkness reserved, and a suffering. The volume does not say that these decide the question. It says that Jude 7 is one of several places in which the language is more naturally read as describing a condition of the persons than the end of them, and that it takes its place in the cumulative case.

The three passages and what each carries.

Passage	What the adjective is set on	What the volume takes from it
Matthew 25:46	The punishment and the life, by the same adjective	The parallel is natural; the persons go into each; the adjective may name a result, and the volume does not rest on it alone
Daniel 12:2	The contempt and the life, by the same adjective	A contempt that is everlasting presupposes persons held in it; this is Inferred
Jude 7	The fire, with the cities set forth as an example	The conditionalist reading is granted as possible; the example, the chains and the suffering are read as pointing past the ashes

6.5 What the adjective does and does not decide

The chapter began with a claim, and the claim has been kept. The adjective in these three passages can describe a result. It can also describe a state that lasts. No grammar settles which, and the volume does not pretend it does. What settles it, if anything does, is what the passages say the persons do and what is done to them. In Matthew 25 they go away into the punishment and into the fire shared with the devil and his angels. In Daniel 12 they awake to a shame that does not end. In Jude 7 the cities are an example of a vengeance suffered. In each, the persons are the subject of what is said, and the verb is not the verb of ending.

The Scripture also says that “the wrath of God abideth” on the one who believes not the Son (John 3:36), and “abideth” is a word for what remains and does not pass. The statement is made of the living and is not a statement about the age to come, and the volume uses it only to say that the New Testament speaks of wrath that remains on persons. The adjectives of this chapter are of the same kind: they speak of persons and of an outcome that does not lapse.

What the volume takes from the passages

- One adjective stands on the punishment and on the life in Matthew 25:46, and the persons go into each; the volume does not read the adjective in two senses.
- The adjective can describe a lasting result, as in eternal redemption, eternal salvation and eternal judgment; the volume grants this and rests nothing on the adjective alone.
- Matthew 25 is a word to Israel at the King’s return and is a witness to the fate of the wicked, not a word to the Body.
- Daniel 12:2 sets an everlasting contempt beside everlasting life, and a contempt that goes on presupposes those who are held in it; this is Inferred.
- Jude 7 can be read as an example of a result, and the volume grants it; the chains, the darkness reserved and the suffering of the same sentence point past that reading.
- None of the three passages is made to prove continuing experience by itself; each is a part of the cumulative case.

7. The Fire and the Worm: Mark 9:43–48 and Isaiah 66:24

Claim: the Lord's words about a worm that dieth not and a fire that is not quenched are quoted from Isaiah, and Isaiah's verse is a picture of corpses. The volume says so first. The Lord's use of the picture is not Isaiah's use, because He sets it before living persons as a place into which they may be cast, and the volume reads His words for what they state of the persons and not for what the fire consumes.

7.1 The setting of Mark 9

The words are spoken at Capernaum. The Twelve had disputed by the way about which of them should be greatest, and the Lord "sat down, and called the twelve", and set a child in the midst of them (Mark 9:33–36). He then warns of offending "one of these little ones that believe in me", and says that for such an offender "it is better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck, and he were cast into the sea" (Mark 9:42). The warning that follows is addressed to the disciples and is spoken in the Kingdom ministry, in the same chapter in which the Lord says that some standing there would not taste of death "till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power" (Mark 9:1). The volume reads the warning in that setting. It is the Lord's word to Israel's disciples about the fate that awaits those who cause the little ones to stumble, and it is not applied to the Body of Christ.

The warning is built on three examples: the hand, the foot and the eye. Of the hand the Lord says, "if thy hand offend thee, cut it off: it is better for thee to enter into life maimed, than having two hands to go into hell, into the fire that never shall be quenched: Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched" (Mark 9:43, 44). The foot and the eye follow in the same form, and each ends with the same clause. The King James Version prints the clause three times, at verses 44, 46 and 48. Some editions do not print it at verses 44 and 46, and the volume does not rest on them. Verse 48 stands in every edition, and it is enough: "Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched" (Mark 9:48).

7.2 What the verses state

Four things are stated. The first is that the choice is between two places: to "enter into life" (verse 43) or "into the kingdom of God" (verse 47) maimed, or to "be cast into hell" whole. The second is that the place of the second choice is called hell, the word the Gospels use for the valley of Hinnom, and that in it there is a fire "that never shall be quenched". The third is that the worm is spoken of as belonging to the persons: "their worm". The fourth is that the verse says of it that it "dieth not", and says of the fire that it "is not quenched". The sentence is in the present tense, and it does not say that the fire will go out or that the worm will end.

Three things are not stated. The verses do not say that those cast into hell cease to be. They do not say that they are conscious. They do not describe what the worm does to them. The words are a picture, and the Lord gives no interpretation of the picture beyond the words. It is for this reason that the origin of the picture matters, and the volume turns to it.

7.3 Isaiah 66:24

The clause is the last verse of Isaiah's prophecy. The prophet has been speaking of the new heavens and the new earth, which "shall remain before me, saith the LORD, so shall your seed and your name remain" (Isaiah 66:22). The nations are gathered to see the Lord's glory, and His own people are brought from all nations to "my holy mountain Jerusalem" (Isaiah 66:20). "And it shall come to pass, that from one new moon to another, and from one sabbath to another, shall all flesh come to worship before me, saith the LORD" (Isaiah 66:23). The last verse follows: "And they shall go forth, and look upon the carcases of the men that have transgressed against me: for their worm shall not die, neither shall their fire be quenched; and they shall be an abhorring unto all flesh" (Isaiah 66:24).

The verse is a picture of corpses, and the volume says so without qualification. The word is "carcases". The persons who go forth are the worshippers of the Lord, they look at what lies there, and what they see is dead men with a worm and a fire at their work. An annihilationist reader takes this as the clearest evidence in the Old Testament that the end of the wicked is their destruction, and the argument has force. A worm that feeds on a dead body and a fire that burns it are agents of consumption, and nothing in the verse says that the body is alive.

The second point on the other side is about the word "quenched". In the Old Testament a fire that is not quenched is a fire that no one can put out, and it burns until what it burns is finished. Of Jerusalem the Lord says, "then will I kindle a fire in the gates thereof, and it shall devour the palaces of Jerusalem, and it shall not be quenched" (Jeremiah 17:27). Of the forest of the south, "the flaming flame shall not be quenched, and all faces from the south to the north shall be burned therein" (Ezekiel 20:47). The fire in Jerusalem's gates is not burning today, and the unquenched fire of Ezekiel's forest did its work and ended. John's words at the Jordan of the one who comes after him carry the same idea: he "will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire" (Matthew 3:12), and chaff is burned up. The volume grants all of this. An unquenchable fire is a fire that cannot be put out, and the phrase does not say that what is thrown into it never burns away.

Where a fire is said not to be quenched.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Jeremiah 17:27	But if ye will not hearken unto me to hallow the sabbath day, and not to bear a burden, even entering in at the gates of Jerusalem on the sabbath day; then will I kindle a fire in the gates thereof, and it shall devour the palaces of Jerusalem, and it shall not be quenched.	A fire in the gates of Jerusalem that devours the palaces and is not quenched; the palaces are consumed.
Ezekiel 20:47	And say to the forest of the south, Hear the word of the LORD; Thus saith the Lord GOD; Behold, I will kindle a fire in thee, and it shall devour every green tree in thee, and every dry tree: the flaming flame shall not be quenched, and all faces from the south to the north shall be burned therein.	A flaming flame in the forest that is not quenched, and the trees are burned.
Matthew 3:12	Whose fan is in his hand, and he will throughly purge his floor, and gather his wheat into the garner; but he will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire.	The chaff is burned up with unquenchable fire; the fire is not said to continue after the chaff.
Isaiah 66:24	And they shall go forth, and look upon the carcases of the men that have transgressed against me: for their worm shall not die, neither shall their fire be quenched; and they shall be an abhorring unto all flesh.	The worm shall not die and the fire shall not be quenched, and the persons are described as carcases.
Mark 9:48	Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched.	The same clause, set in the Lord's warning to His disciples about being cast into hell.

7.4 What the Lord does with the verse

Nothing so far makes Mark 9:48 say more than Isaiah 66:24. The question is whether the Lord uses the clause as the prophet does, and the volume holds that He does not. The prophet's scene is of persons who have died and are seen by others. The Lord's scene is of persons who are alive and who are warned against the casting. "It is better for thee to enter into life maimed, than having two hands to go into hell" is a sentence about a living man who has two hands, and the choice is between going into life without a hand and going into hell with both. The man goes into the fire as himself, and the clause that follows says what is at the place: their worm, and a fire. The Lord

does not say that they are seen as carcases. He says they are “cast into hell”, and the picture that He takes from Isaiah is a picture of what is there.

The Lord had already used the same warning in the Sermon on the Mount: “it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish, and not that thy whole body should be cast into hell” (Matthew 5:29, 30). The member perishes, and the whole body is cast into hell. These are not the same thing in the sentence, and the second is described as what the first prevents. In the same breath He says, “whosoever shall say, Thou fool, shall be in danger of hell fire” (Matthew 5:22). The place is named in the Gospels as a place into which persons are cast, and the body is the object of the casting.

This is Inferred, and the volume marks it. The Lord does not say whether the persons in the place are conscious or whether their worm feeds on what is alive. A reader who holds that the Lord’s picture is the same as Isaiah’s, a picture of the finished destruction of those who are gone, can say so, and the words do not forbid it. The volume holds that the Lord’s sentence is more naturally read as placing the persons in the fire and the worm, and that the “their” of the worm and the “cast” of the persons are the Lord’s own additions to what the prophet had said. It does not rest the case on the verse.

7.5 The valley and the picture

The name of the place carries a history. The valley of the son of Hinnom was the place where the people of Judah “built the high places of Tophet… to burn their sons and their daughters in the fire”, and the Lord said that it should be called “the valley of slaughter”, where “the carcases of this people shall be meat for the fowls of the heaven, and for the beasts of the earth” (Jeremiah 7:31, 33). The prophet gives the same name again in the nineteenth chapter, in the setting of judgment on the city. The Lord’s choice of the name Gehenna, when He speaks of the place of the fire, brings the picture of that valley with it: a place of unburied dead and of fire. The volume grants that this gives the picture a corpse-like colour and that it favours the other side’s reading of the image.

The Lord does not use the name only for the picture. He says to the scribes and Pharisees, “Ye serpents, ye generation of vipers, how can ye escape the damnation of hell?” (Matthew 23:33). The damnation of hell is a judgment of persons who are living and who are addressed. In the Sermon on the Mount He says that the offender is “in danger of hell fire” (Matthew 5:22), and in the commission to the Twelve He says that God is able “to destroy both soul and body in hell” (Matthew 10:28). In each place the persons are the ones who are judged, and the place is the place of judgment. The valley supplies the picture and the sentence supplies the persons.

7.6 The oracle of Edom and what it shows

One more Old Testament passage belongs in the chapter, because it is the other side’s best parallel. In Isaiah 34 the Lord’s indignation is “upon all nations”, and His sword “shall come down upon Idumea, and upon the people of my curse, to judgment” (Isaiah 34:2, 5). The land is described: “the streams thereof shall be turned into pitch, and the dust thereof into brimstone, and the land thereof shall become burning pitch. It shall not be quenched night nor day; the smoke thereof shall go up for ever: from generation to generation it shall lie waste” (Isaiah 34:9, 10). The fire of the oracle is a

fire that does not go out and a smoke that goes up for ever, and the land of Edom is not burning today. The idiom is a way of saying that the ruin is permanent.

The volume grants the point in full and draws the line where it falls. Isaiah's smoke that goes up for ever is the smoke of a land and a nation, and what it says is that the desolation is not undone. The oracle does not describe persons tormented, and the volume does not use it to say that they are. It shows that Scripture speaks of a fire that does not go out and a smoke that does not cease in connection with a judgment that finished its object, and that the words "for ever" in such a place describe the permanence of the ruin. Where Revelation takes up the same imagery of persons, as it does in chapter 14, the words are the words of persons, with "no rest day nor night". The Edom oracle is cited in the Prophets Series, in Volume 3, The Nations Judged, with its own question, and this volume takes only the idiom from it.

7.7 Weeping and gnashing of teeth

The Lord's account of the end uses another phrase that bears on what is at the place. Of the wheat and the tares He says, "The Son of man shall send forth his angels, and they shall gather out of his kingdom all things that offend, and them which do iniquity; And shall cast them into a furnace of fire: there shall be wailing and gnashing of teeth" (Matthew 13:41, 42). The same sentence is spoken of the dragnet in the next parable (Matthew 13:50). It is said of the children of the kingdom who are cast out (Matthew 8:12), of the man without a wedding garment (Matthew 22:13), of the unprofitable servant (Matthew 25:30) and of the servant who is cut asunder and given his portion with the hypocrites (Matthew 24:51). In Luke it is said of those who see Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of God "and you yourselves thrust out" (Luke 13:28).

The phrase is an expression of a person's distress. It is not what happens to the fuel of a fire. The tares are burned in the fire (Matthew 13:40), and the volume does not build on the parable's picture of burning. It notes that the Lord places the wailing at the furnace: "there shall be wailing". The word "there" is the word that tells the reader that what is described is a condition at the place, and a condition of persons who are able to wail. This is shown by the context. The parables are read in their own place in the Parable Studies, and this volume uses them only for the phrase.

What the fire passages say of the persons and what they leave out.

Passage	What is said of the persons	What is not said
Isaiah 66:24	They are carcases, seen by the worshippers; the worm and the fire are with them	That they are alive; that they are conscious
Mark 9:43–48	A man with two hands is cast into hell, into the fire that is not quenched; their worm dieth not	What the worm and the fire do; whether the person is conscious
Matthew 5:29, 30	The whole body is cast into hell, set against the loss of a member	How long the body is there

Passage	What is said of the persons	What is not said
Matthew 13:41, 42	They are cast into a furnace of fire; there is wailing and gnashing of teeth	Whether the wailing is for a moment or for ever
Isaiah 34:9, 10	A land is turned to burning pitch; the smoke goes up for ever	Any person tormented; the oracle is of a land

What the volume takes from the passages

- Mark 9:43–48 is the Lord's warning to His disciples in the Kingdom ministry, and it quotes the last verse of Isaiah.
- Isaiah 66:24 is a picture of corpses; the volume grants that it supports a reading in which the fire and the worm consume the dead.
- A fire that is not quenched is a fire that cannot be put out; Jeremiah 17:27, Ezekiel 20:47 and Matthew 3:12 show that the fire may finish its work, and the volume grants it.
- The Lord does not say "carcases"; He says that a living man with two hands is cast into hell, and that their worm dieth not.
- The valley of Hinnom gives the picture a corpse-like colour, and the Lord's use of the name for persons judged is a use of the name for the place of judgment.
- The Edom oracle shows that a smoke that goes up for ever can be the permanence of a ruin; it describes a land and tells nothing of persons tormented.
- Weeping and gnashing of teeth is set at the place of casting out, and it is the distress of persons.

8. Revelation 14:9–11 and 20:10–15

Claim: in Revelation the final punishment is described by the persons who are in it. The third angel says that they are tormented and have no rest day nor night. The seer says that the beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake of fire, that the devil is cast in a thousand years later, and that a plural statement of torment, day and night for ever and ever, follows. The lake is called the second death, and Revelation's own portrayal of the first death does not describe the person's ceasing. This chapter reads the passages in five parts and says in the last what stands at the throne and who.

8.1 Revelation 14:9–11

The book names its audience at the outset. It is "The Revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave unto him, to shew unto his servants things which must shortly come to pass" (Revelation 1:1), and it is sent by John "to the seven churches which are in Asia" (Revelation 1:4). Its visions are visions of events still to come. The volume reads the fourteenth chapter in that frame. The Lamb stands "on the mount Sion", and with Him "an hundred forty and four thousand, having his Father's name written in their foreheads" (Revelation 14:1). Angels fly in the midst of heaven. The first has "the everlasting gospel to preach unto them that dwell on the earth" (Revelation 14:6), the second announces that Babylon is fallen, and the third follows with a warning. The warning concerns those who worship the beast, and it is not a warning to the Body of

Christ. The volume uses it for what it reveals of the fate of the wicked in the days it describes.

The third angel's words are these: "If any man worship the beast and his image, and receive his mark in his forehead, or in his hand, The same shall drink of the wine of the wrath of God, which is poured out without mixture into the cup of his indignation; and he shall be tormented with fire and brimstone in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb: And the smoke of their torment ascendeth up for ever and ever: and they have no rest day nor night, who worship the beast and his image, and whosoever receiveth the mark of his name" (Revelation 14:9–11).

The sentence has four parts, and the volume asks what each states. The first is the cup: the wrath of God, poured out without mixture. The second is the torment: "he shall be tormented with fire and brimstone", and it takes place "in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb". The third is the smoke: "the smoke of their torment ascendeth up for ever and ever". The fourth is the statement about the persons: "they have no rest day nor night".

The smoke is the part on which the other side puts its finger, and the volume grants what is true in the objection. In Isaiah 34, as chapter 7 saw, the smoke of a land that goes up for ever is the idiom for a ruin that is permanent, and Revelation says the same of Babylon: "her smoke rose up for ever and ever" (Revelation 19:3). If the verse said only that the smoke goes up for ever, it could be taken as a monument of a thing destroyed. The volume does not rest on the smoke.

It rests on the whole statement. The smoke is "the smoke of their torment", and the noun of torment is a word for what is felt. In the fifth trumpet the locusts are given power that men "should be tormented five months: and their torment was as the torment of a scorpion, when he striketh a man" (Revelation 9:5), and "in those days shall men seek death, and shall not find it; and shall desire to die, and death shall flee from them" (Revelation 9:6). The fifth vial brings a darkness in which men "gnawed their tongues for pain, And blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores" (Revelation 16:10, 11). The two prophets are said to have "tormented them that dwelt on the earth" (Revelation 11:10). In each place the book uses its words for torment of what is suffered by someone who is aware of it. In chapter 14 the torment is of "he" and "their", persons, and it is "in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb", so that it has witnesses.

The last clause is the one on which the argument leans, and the volume says plainly what it does and does not state. The passage explicitly says three things: they shall be tormented; the smoke of their torment ascendeth up for ever and ever; and they have no rest day nor night. The words "for ever and ever" belong to the smoke and are not set on the no-rest clause. What the no-rest clause says is said of persons, and a person who does not exist has neither rest nor lack of rest. It is also the negative of what the saints are given: two verses later the voice from heaven says of those who die in the Lord, "that they may rest from their labours" (Revelation 14:13). The conclusion that the experience does not end emerges most strongly when this passage is read beside Revelation 20:10 (section 8.2), and not by inserting "for ever and ever" into the no-rest clause. The three statements are Stated in the sentence; the contrast with the saints' rest is shown by the verse that follows; and the conclusion of unending experience is Inferred from the two passages together.

The writer who holds that the lost cease to exist has two replies, and the volume gives both. The first is that “day nor night” describes the time during which the torment goes on and does not say that the time is without end, and that the “for ever and ever” of the sentence belongs to the smoke. The second is that Revelation’s language is symbolic throughout and that a smoke is a symbol. The volume grants the first as to the grammar of the clause, and it answers it by pointing to the second half of Revelation 20:10, where the phrase “day and night for ever and ever” is set on the verb of torment itself (section 8.2). It answers the second by noting that the book’s symbols are used of realities, and that when it says “he shall be tormented” it describes persons. The volume does not say that the reply is without difficulty. It says that the sentence, read whole, describes persons who have no rest, and that this is said in the same words as the verses in which a man is tormented by a scorpion’s sting.

The torment words in Revelation.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Revelation 9:5, 6	And to them it was given that they should not kill them, but that they should be tormented five months: and their torment was as the torment of a scorpion, when he striketh a man. And in those days shall men seek death, and shall not find it; and shall desire to die, and death shall flee from them.	Men are tormented five months, as by a scorpion’s sting, and seek death and do not find it.
Revelation 11:10	And they that dwell upon the earth shall rejoice over them, and make merry, and shall send gifts one to another; because these two prophets tormented them that dwelt on the earth.	The two prophets tormented them that dwelt on the earth.
Revelation 14:10, 11	The same shall drink of the wine of the wrath of God, which is poured out without mixture into the cup of his indignation; and he shall be tormented with fire and brimstone in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb: And the smoke of their torment ascendeth up for ever and ever: and they have no rest day nor night, who worship the beast and his image, and whosoever receiveth the mark of his name.	The worshippers of the beast are tormented in the presence of the holy angels and the Lamb; the smoke of their torment ascends; they have no rest day nor night.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Revelation 16:10, 11	And the fifth angel poured out his vial upon the seat of the beast; and his kingdom was full of darkness; and they gnawed their tongues for pain, And blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores, and repented not of their deeds.	Men gnaw their tongues for pain and blaspheme because of their pains and their sores.

8.2 Revelation 20:10, with 19:20

The second passage is a matter of two verses a thousand years apart. At the Lord's coming in the nineteenth chapter, "the beast was taken, and with him the false prophet that wrought miracles before him, with which he deceived them that had received the mark of the beast, and them that worshipped his image. These both were cast alive into a lake of fire burning with brimstone" (Revelation 19:20). The next verse tells that "the remnant were slain with the sword of him that sat upon the horse" (Revelation 19:21), and the narrative passes to the binding of Satan for a thousand years (Revelation 20:1–3). The thousand years run their course, Satan is loosed, goes out to deceive the nations, and a fire from God devours the host that compasses the camp of the saints (Revelation 20:7–9). The next verse reads: "And the devil that deceived them was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone, where the beast and the false prophet are, and shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever" (Revelation 20:10).

The King James Version supplies the word "are" in "where the beast and the false prophet are". The Greek text does not contain an explicit verb corresponding to the supplied "are", and the volume does not build on that word. The stronger evidence is the plural statement that follows: "shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever". In the natural reading of the sentence, the devil, the beast, and the false prophet are included in the plural subject. The passage therefore presents all three as sharing the torment of the lake, although the continued presence of the beast and false prophet should be classified as shown by the construction rather than established by an explicit present-tense verb. The beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake at the beginning of the thousand years (Revelation 19:20), and the devil is cast into the same lake at the end of them. A reader who holds that the lake destroys at once what is cast into it has to give an account of two persons who were cast in a thousand years earlier and are named with the devil in the statement of torment. The volume reads the beast and the false prophet as persons, as Volume 2 of the Prophetic Commentary Series, The Beast and the False Prophet, does, and it takes "cast alive" in the nineteenth chapter as the plain sense of persons being thrown into the lake without having died.

The second half of the verse is the statement about the three: "shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever". The verb of torment is plural, and the natural reading takes the three as its subject: the devil, the beast and the false prophet. The phrase "day and night" is the phrase of Revelation 14:11, and "for ever and ever" is the strongest phrase of duration that the book has. The same words are used of the One who "liveth for ever and ever" (Revelation 4:9, 10; 10:6), of the Lord Christ who "shall

reign for ever and ever" (Revelation 11:15), and of the saints, of whom it is said at the end that they "shall reign for ever and ever" (Revelation 22:5). The book does not use a weaker phrase when it speaks of the lake. It uses the phrase that it uses of God's life and of the saints' reign.

The other side has three answers. The first is that the beast and the false prophet are symbols of systems, and that systems are destroyed and not tormented. The second is that the devil is an angelic being of a different order and that what is said of him is not said of the human lost. The third is that Daniel's beast was "slain, and his body destroyed, and given to the burning flame" (Daniel 7:11), and that the Revelation scene is the same event, in which the beast is destroyed. The volume replies to each in turn. It reads the beast and the false prophet as persons, because of the words "cast alive". It grants that the devil is not a man, and it says that the verse does not turn on what the devil is: it sets the three in one place and says one thing of them. And it reads Daniel 7:11 as a verse about the beast in the vision of Daniel, in which the body is given to a fire, and it finds that Revelation 19:20 adds to it that the beast and the false prophet were cast alive into a lake of fire and are there a thousand years later. The addition is the point.

This passage is marked as follows. That the beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake is Stated (19:20). That the devil is later cast into the same lake is Stated (20:10). That the plural statement of torment embraces the devil, the beast and the false prophet is shown by the grammar and the context. That the beast and the false prophet remain conscious throughout the thousand years is Inferred from the combined sequence and the plural statement of torment. That the lake destroys on contact is not stated by the passage.

8.3 The second death and the lake of fire

The question of this section is a narrow one, and it is not answered beforehand. Revelation calls the lake of fire "the second death" (Revelation 20:14; 21:8). Does the name require that those who are cast into it cease to exist? The volume does not define death before it has read the book. It asks what the book says the second death is, and what it says death is wherever it uses the word.

What the book says of the lake is this. It is a place into which persons are cast: the beast and the false prophet alive (Revelation 19:20), the devil (Revelation 20:10), Death and Hades (Revelation 20:14), and "whosoever was not found written in the book of life" (Revelation 20:15). It is a lake "which burneth with fire and brimstone" (Revelation 21:8), the verb being a verb of continuing burning. Those who are in it are described by the verb of torment (Revelation 20:10). The persons for whom it is prepared are named by their works: "the fearful, and unbelieving, and the abominable, and murderers, and whoremongers, and sorcerers, and idolaters, and all liars, shall have their part in the lake" (Revelation 21:8). The word "part" is the word for a portion, a share in something that is there. Of those who overcome it is said that they "shall not be hurt of the second death" (Revelation 2:11), and "on such the second death hath no power" (Revelation 20:6). A thing that can hurt, and that has power, is spoken of as something that acts.

What the book says of death is no less to the point. The fourth seal reveals a pale horse: "his name that sat on him was Death, and Hell followed with him" (Revelation 6:8). Death is a rider and Hell follows. When the dead are judged, "the sea gave up the

dead which were in it; and death and hell delivered up the dead which were in them" (Revelation 20:13). The dead are persons. They are in Death and Hades, they are given up, and they stand: "I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God" (Revelation 20:12). In the book's portrayal, those held in the first death continue as persons: they are in the realm of the dead, where they are kept until they are brought out and stand before the throne.

This is the point of the section, and it is a narrow one. Revelation portrays those held in the first death as continuing persons who are subsequently raised and judged. This establishes that "death" within Revelation does not inherently mean cessation of existence. The volume therefore reads "second death" in light of the lake's own descriptions, its torment, its burning and its "part", rather than assuming that the word death means extinction. That the second death names the condition of persons in the lake is Inferred from Revelation's use of death and from the context of the lake's description. It is the volume's reading, and it is not a demonstration that the second death must function as the first does. A different book, or a different verse, may use death of the end of a life, as in Genesis 7, and the volume has said so (chapter 3). The reading is of Revelation by Revelation.

One more statement of the book bears on it. The final enemy is spoken of in the same terms by Paul: "The last enemy that shall be destroyed is death" (1 Corinthians 15:26). In Revelation, when the last enemy is dealt with, Death and Hades are cast into the lake (Revelation 20:14), and the next scene is the new heaven and the new earth in which "there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain" (Revelation 21:4). The lake is not said to be emptied or to cease in those chapters. It stands over against the city: "the fearful, and unbelieving… shall have their part in the lake" (Revelation 21:8), and in the city "there shall in no wise enter into it any thing that defileth… but they which are written in the Lamb's book of life" (Revelation 21:27). The volume reports the verses and does not say more than they say. They do not say that the lake is ended.

What Revelation says of the lake and of death.

Point	The verse	The mark
The lake is called the second death	Revelation 20:14; 21:8	Stated
The beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake	Revelation 19:20	Stated
The devil is later cast into the same lake	Revelation 20:10	Stated
The plural statement of torment embraces the devil, the beast and the false prophet	Revelation 20:10	shown by the grammar and the context
The beast and the false prophet remain conscious through the thousand years	Revelation 19:20; 20:10	Inferred
The lake burneth with fire and brimstone	Revelation 21:8	Stated

Point	The verse	The mark
The dead stand before God and are judged	Revelation 20:12, 13	Stated
Death in the book does not inherently describe the person's ceasing	Revelation 6:8; 20:12–14	shown by the context
The second death names the condition of persons in the lake	Revelation 20:10, 14; 21:8	Inferred

8.4 Revelation 20:11–15 read for what it establishes of final punishment

The throne scene is read here for one thing: what it says about the punishment that follows. The seer writes, "And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away; and there was found no place for them" (Revelation 20:11). The dead "small and great" stand before God, books are opened, and "the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works" (Revelation 20:12). The sea, Death and Hades give up their dead, and "they were judged every man according to their works" (Revelation 20:13). Then the sentence is carried out: "And death and hell were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death. And whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:14, 15).

Three things follow from the text, and they are the volume's only claims from it. The first is that the judgment is individual and according to works: each is judged "every man according to their works" (Revelation 20:13). The second is that the sentence is a casting into the lake, which is an act done to persons. The third is that the passage does not say that the lake is emptied or that those cast into it cease. It says that they are cast in, and the preceding section has shown what the book says of the lake.

A judgment that is according to works is a judgment in which the persons are not all treated alike. The Lord said as much in the days of His ministry to Israel. Of Tyre and Sidon He said that it would be "more tolerable" for them "at the day of judgment" than for the cities that saw His works (Matthew 11:22), and of Sodom the same (Matthew 11:24). Of the servant who knew his lord's will and did it not He said that he "shall be beaten with many stripes", and of him who knew not, "few stripes" (Luke 12:47, 48). Of the scribes and Pharisees He said, "ye shall receive the greater damnation" (Matthew 23:14), and the letter to the Hebrews speaks of "sorer punishment" for him who has trodden under foot the Son of God (Hebrews 10:29). These words were spoken to Israel and to the Hebrew readers, and they are witnesses of what Scripture reveals of the day of judgment and not words to the Body. They state that the punishment is graded.

The writer who holds that the lost cease to exist grants this and says that the grading is in the measure of suffering before the end. The volume grants that this is a possible reading, and that degrees alone do not decide the question. It says that a punishment which can be more tolerable or less, which is a measure of stripes, and which is said to be "greater" and "sorer", is described as something the persons have, with a content and a measure. That is shown by the context. It does not say that the content is never completed. It says that the descriptions the Scripture uses are the descriptions of an infliction, and not of a ceasing.

8.5 Who stands at the great white throne

The question is a natural one, and the passage raises it. Who are “the dead, small and great”? The volume asks it because its own subject requires an answer. The people whom the text says are cast into the lake are the people whose punishment the volume describes, and it is fair to ask who they are. The answer is argued from the chapter, and each step is marked.

The company at the throne

Revelation 20:12 does not call the company by a name beyond “the dead, small and great”. Verse 13 adds that the sea, Death and Hades give up their dead, which says where they were, and that they are judged “every man according to their works”. The identification of this company with “the rest of the dead” is a conclusion drawn from the sequence of the chapter. In verse 4 the seer sees thrones and those who sat upon them, and “the souls of them that were beheaded for the witness of Jesus, and for the word of God”, who “lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years”. Verse 5 says, “But the rest of the dead lived not again until the thousand years were finished. This is the first resurrection.” The thousand years end in verse 7, and the throne stands in verse 11. The dead who stand before the throne are the dead who lived again when the thousand years were finished, and this is the group verse 5 calls the rest of the dead. The volume marks this as shown by the context and Inferred from the sequence. It is not Stated in verse 12. Verse 12 does not say “the rest”.

Who is excluded, and why

Two companies are not at the throne for the judgment that ends in the lake. The first is the company of the first resurrection. Of them the text says, “Blessed and holy is he that hath part in the first resurrection: on such the second death hath no power” (Revelation 20:6). The second death is the lake (Revelation 20:14), and those on whom it has no power are not cast into it. Because the second death has no power over the first-resurrection company, they cannot be included among those condemned to the lake. The volume therefore distinguishes them from the company subjected to the throne’s final sentence. This is Stated in verse 6 for the power of the second death, and it is shown by the context for their absence from the throne.

The second is the Body of Christ. The Body’s accounting is set elsewhere: “we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ” (Romans 14:10), and “we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad” (2 Corinthians 5:10). That is a different court, with a different seat, a different people and a different end, and its nature is the subject of Volume 5 of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series, Separate Courts. That the Body does not appear in the scenes of Revelation, and that the great white throne is not its judgment, is a conclusion the volume draws from the audience and setting of Revelation as a whole. It is marked Inferred, and it is not established by Romans 14:10 and 2 Corinthians 5:10 alone, which show only that the Body’s accounting is set at another seat.

Works and the book of life

The passage speaks of two kinds of record, and the volume keeps them apart. The books are opened, and “the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works” (Revelation 20:12). That is one function: the books supply the record by which the dead are judged by their works. “And another

book was opened, which is the book of life": that is a second book, and the verse names it separately. Its function is stated at the end: "whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:15). The criterion of the casting is not being found written.

The text does not say how the two books are related, and the volume does not make it say. It does not say that a person judged by works is found written in the book of life. It does not say that no one at the throne is. It says that the dead are judged by their works and that whoever is not found written is cast in. Elsewhere the book speaks of the book of life in other terms: "he that overcometh, the same shall be clothed in white raiment; and I will not blot out his name out of the book of life" (Revelation 3:5), and the new Jerusalem receives only "they which are written in the Lamb's book of life" (Revelation 21:27). These are statements of what the book of life is for. They tell nothing of the relation between the books and the book of life at the throne. The volume holds both functions intact.

Those who believed in the thousand years

One question is left, and the volume asks it plainly: does anyone who believed during the thousand years stand at the throne, and how? The text of chapter 20 names the thousand years' people in one place. When Satan is loosed, he goes out "to deceive the nations which are in the four quarters of the earth, Gog and Magog", and they "went up on the breadth of the earth, and compassed the camp of the saints about, and the beloved city: and fire came down from God out of heaven, and devoured them" (Revelation 20:8, 9). So there are nations on the earth at the end of the thousand years, and there is a camp of saints. The prophets describe the age in which they live: "the child shall die an hundred years old; but the sinner being an hundred years old shall be accursed" (Isaiah 65:20), and "every one that is left of all the nations which came against Jerusalem shall even go up from year to year to worship the King, the LORD of hosts" (Zechariah 14:16). The new earth has "the nations of them which are saved" (Revelation 21:24).

The prophetic passages describe mortal life and death within the kingdom setting, surviving nations worshipping the King, and saved nations in the New Earth. They do not explicitly explain when kingdom believers who die are raised or whether any appear at the Great White Throne. The volume has asked the question and examined these passages, and the text does not answer it. The volume leaves it open and does not fill the gap. Nothing in the argument about the lake depends on the answer.

The earlier volume

Volume 5 of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series, Separate Courts, set the great white throne among the courts of Scripture and left two points open on purpose: whether anyone who believed during the thousand years stands at the throne, and how the works and the book of life relate. This volume examines those questions because its own question requires it. Where it goes further than that volume, as in the identification of the throne company with the rest of the dead, it says so and marks the step as drawn from the sequence of the chapter. Where it does not, as in the thousand-year question and the relation of the books, it stands where that volume stood. It does not say that the earlier volume was wrong, and it does not rewrite its words.

Who stands at the great white throne, and what is claimed.

Question	The volume's position	The mark
Who stands	The dead, small and great, whom the sea, Death, and Hades give up	Stated (20:12, 13)
They are the rest of the dead of 20:5	Drawn from the order of the chapter; verse 12 does not say so	shown by the context; Inferred
The first-resurrection company is not cast into the lake	The second death has no power over it	Stated (20:6)
The Body is not judged here	Its accounting is the judgment seat of Christ; the Body's absence from Revelation's scenes is the volume's conclusion from the book's audience and setting	Inferred (Romans 14:10; 2 Corinthians 5:10 set its accounting at another seat)
The books and the book of life	Two functions, kept apart; no relation drawn	Stated (20:12, 15)
Those who believed in the thousand years	Not answered by the text; left open	Left open

What the volume takes from the chapter

- Revelation names its audience and describes events still to come; its warnings to the worshippers of the beast are witnesses to the fate of the wicked and not words to the Body.
- Revelation 14:9–11 does not rest on the smoke. It says that the worshippers of the beast are tormented and have no rest day nor night, and it sets that beside the rest of those who die in the Lord.
- The torment words of the book describe what is suffered by someone who is aware of it.
- The beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake, the devil is cast into it a thousand years later, and the plural statement of torment at Revelation 20:10 takes in all three; the supplied "are" is not relied on.
- The lake is called the second death; in the book's own portrayal the dead exist, stand and are judged, so death does not inherently mean the person's ceasing.
- The judgment is according to works and is graded; the passage does not say the lake is emptied or ended.
- The great white throne company is identified with the rest of the dead from the sequence of the chapter, marked as Inferred; the first-resurrection company is distinguished from it by Revelation 20:6, and the Body's absence is a conclusion from the book's audience and setting.
- The books and the book of life are kept as two functions, and the question of those who believed in the thousand years is left open.

9. Objections and Replies

Claim: the case against annihilationism is not strengthened by weakening the other side. The writers who hold that the lost cease to exist argue from Scripture, and their strongest arguments are stated here in their own best form, beside the writers who answer them. Each objection is answered from Scripture, and what is granted is said first.

9.1 Who is named and how

On the side that holds the lost cease to exist, five writers are named. Basil Atkinson, an English conditionalist of the last century, is known here through Robert Peterson's study of his exegesis, and his positions are described as Peterson reports them. Edward Fudge, in The Fire That Consumes, gives the fullest scriptural case for conditional immortality in English. John Stott, in a dialogue with David Edwards published in 1988, said that he held the view, tentatively, and asked for it to be debated. Clark Pinnock argued in an article of 1990 that the finally impenitent are destroyed. John Wenham, in The Goodness of God, took the same position. The primary texts of Fudge, Stott, Pinnock and Wenham were not accessible or available at the time of this writing, and the volume describes their positions in its own words, naming the author and the work, without quotation marks.

On the side of the volume, three writers are named. Robert Peterson, in an article on Atkinson in The Churchman, answers the exegesis of Basil Atkinson passage by passage. Marlin Woodier, in an article in Evangel, defends the traditional doctrine from the same Scriptures. Andy Saville, in an article in the Scottish Bulletin of Evangelical Theology, answers the doctrinal arguments of Stott, Pinnock, Wenham, Fudge and others. Alan Linfield's survey of the debate in the Evangelical Review of Theology is used for the names of those who hold the conditionalist view. Each of these is quoted only where the volume has read the actual words in a free full text. The volume cites by article and does not give page numbers.

9.2 The objection from the words of destruction

The objection. The New Testament speaks of the end of the lost in the words of destruction, perishing and death, and in the Old Testament the same words describe the end of what is destroyed. When Scripture says that God is able to destroy soul and body in hell, that the end of the enemies of the cross is destruction and that the wicked shall be punished with everlasting destruction, the plain sense is that they are destroyed, and a thing that is destroyed is no more. Fudge builds the case on this, and Atkinson's exegesis, as Peterson describes it, treats the destruction as the end of the person.

What is granted. The words do describe an ending in many verses, as chapter 3 showed from Genesis 7, Daniel 2 and Matthew 12. The soul is not indestructible by nature, and Matthew 10:28 does not say that it is. The objection from the ordinary sense of the words is a fair one, and the volume has not tried to weaken it.

The reply. The ordinary sense of the words is not one sense. A lost sheep is a sheep that is alive, a waste of ointment is ointment that was spent and is not gone from the world, and a man delivered to Satan "for the destruction of the flesh" is a man who is saved (1 Corinthians 5:5). Death itself is used of one who is alive. Of the son who came home the father says, "this my son was dead, and is alive again" (Luke 15:24),

and the apostle says of the saints, “you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins” (Ephesians 2:1). Woodier reads death in Genesis 2:17 as separation and not extinction, pointing to the broken fellowship and the exclusion from the garden in Genesis 3. The volume adds a plain observation from the text: the man who was told that in the day he ate he should surely die went on living, and “all the days that Adam lived were nine hundred and thirty years: and he died” (Genesis 5:5). The first death cannot be read as the man’s ceasing on the day he ate. The question is therefore what the words mean in a given passage, and that is decided by the passage. Chapters 4 and 5 read the two verses the objection leans on most and found that each states a power or an end and says nothing of its manner.

9.3 The objection from the word eternal

The objection. “Eternal” describes the result of an action and not the action itself. On the reading Peterson reports of Atkinson, an adjective of this kind set on a noun of action refers to the result, so that “everlasting punishment” is a punishment done once with permanent results, as “eternal redemption” is a redemption done once. Fudge adds that the adjective has a qualitative sense as well as a quantitative one, and can describe a thing of the age to come without saying how long the experience lasts. Linfield’s survey of the debate sets the same point beside the others.

What is granted. The adjective is used in this way in Hebrews 9:12, Hebrews 5:9 and Hebrews 6:2. Chapter 6 granted that it can describe a result and that Matthew 25:46 does not by itself decide the question.

The reply. Peterson’s answer to Atkinson’s rule is that it is unsupported by the language and that it breaks the parallel with “life eternal”. The volume goes with the first of his points in part and with the second in full. It does not rest on a grammatical rule about nouns of action, and it does not say that the adjective carries the case. It says that the persons “go away into everlasting punishment” as the righteous go into life, and that the passages about the persons in the lake, taken with the adjective, describe persons who are in the lake and are not described as finishing. Peterson judges the conditionalist exegesis of Revelation 14:10, 11 “an evasion of the text and not a literal exegesis”, and the volume does not use words so strong. It says that an exegesis which gives the account of the smoke and passes over “no rest day nor night” has not answered the verse.

9.4 The objection from the fire and the worm

The objection. A fire that is not quenched consumes what it burns, and a worm that does not die is a worm that eats. The last verse of Isaiah is a picture of corpses, and the Lord’s words in Mark 9:48 are a quotation of it. Atkinson, in Peterson’s report, read the worm as the suffering that comes before the final destruction and the fire as the destruction. Fudge cites the unquenchable fires of Jeremiah 17:27 and Ezekiel 20:47 as fires that finished their work.

What is granted. Isaiah 66:24 is a picture of corpses. Unquenchable fire is fire that cannot be put out, and it can end when its fuel is gone. Isaiah 34:10 uses the language of fire for ever of a land that is not burning now. Chapter 7 granted all of this.

The reply. Peterson finds Atkinson’s exegesis of Mark 9:43, 48 “problematic on a number of counts”, and counts among them, not least, his understanding of Isaiah

66:24. The volume's own reply is the one chapter 7 gave. The Lord does not say "carcases". He says of a man with two hands that he is cast into hell, into the fire that never shall be quenched, where their worm dieth not. He sets the casting against entering into life, and He adds that every one shall be salted with fire (Mark 9:49). The fire is a place the living are cast into, and the picture the Lord takes from Isaiah is the picture of what is at that place. The volume marks the step as Inferred and does not claim more.

9.5 The objection from Revelation's smoke

The objection. The smoke that goes up for ever and ever is the language of a ruin that is permanent. It is the smoke of Edom in Isaiah 34, and it is the smoke of Babylon in Revelation 19:3, and neither is a place of continuing torment. On Atkinson's reading, as Peterson gives it, the burning sulphur consumes the wicked and the smoke rising for ever marks the eternal result of the judgment.

What is granted. The smoke alone does not prove conscious torment, and Revelation 19:3 shows that the book uses the image of a city. The symbols of the book are real symbols.

The reply. The volume does not stand on the smoke. It stands on the persons, who are tormented in the presence of the holy angels and of the Lamb, who have no rest day nor night, and who, in the plural statement of Revelation 20:10, include the beast and the false prophet cast in a thousand years before the devil. The objection answers the sentence about the smoke and does not answer the sentence about the persons. Peterson's judgment of the conditionalist reading is that it must be labelled an evasion of the text. The volume's judgment is milder and the same: the reading leaves two clauses of the third angel's warning, and the plural statement of torment in Revelation 20:10, without an account.

9.6 The objection from justice

The objection. Endless punishment for sins done in a finite life is out of proportion, and a loving God would not inflict it. Stott, in his dialogue with Edwards, said that he found the idea hard to reconcile with the justice of God, and Wenham and Pinnock argued in the same way, as Saville reports their arguments. Pinnock and Stott also made the argument from dualism, that endless torment leaves a part of creation in rebellion for ever.

What is granted. The objection is made in earnest and by writers who love the Scripture. A reader who feels its weight is not to be dismissed, and the volume agrees with Stott that the question must be examined and not ruled out of order.

The reply. The volume does not meet the objection with a rule of proportion that the Scripture does not state. The argument that sin against an infinite God deserves infinite punishment is used by Woodier and by older traditionalists, and the volume does not use it, because no verse states it. It answers from what Scripture does say. The Judge of all the earth does right (Genesis 18:25). His judgments are "true and righteous" (Revelation 16:7; 19:2), and Paul's answer to the question whether God is unrighteous who taketh vengeance is, "God forbid: for then how shall God judge the world?" (Romans 3:5, 6). The judgment is graded (chapter 8). The judgment is of persons by their works, and it is the Lord's own judgment, spoken by the Lord Himself in the passages the volume has read. Saville, who rejects annihilationism, argues in

his article that “extinction cannot be an infinite punishment”, because a punishment that is retributive must be experienced, and he concludes against several traditionalists that extinction is a punishment. The volume notes that his argument is a doctrinal one and does not use it as exegesis. It notes also that the justice objection, taken as an exegetical argument, is an argument from what the reader thinks God would do, and that the volume’s task is to say what the text says He will do.

9.7 The objection from the immortality of the soul

The objection. The idea that the soul is by nature immortal came into the church from Greek philosophy, and it distorted the reading of the passages on the end of the lost. Saville names Travis, Pinnock, Froom and White among those who made the point. Once the idea is set aside, the passages on destruction say what they appear to say.

What is granted. The doctrine of the soul’s natural immortality is not stated in Scripture in so many words, and the volume does not rest on it. Matthew 10:28 says that God is able to destroy the soul.

The reply. The volume’s case does not depend on the soul’s immortality, and Saville’s own judgment of the argument is that it is not decisive. A person may hold that only God has immortality in the sense of life in himself, and that the lost are kept in being by God’s will, and still hold that the passages on the lake describe a continuing experience. The persons are in the lake because the text puts them there and says they are tormented. That is a statement about what God does with them, and it does not require a doctrine of what they are.

9.8 The objection from the earthly judgments of the wicked

The objection. Many passages say that the wicked shall be no more. “For yet a little while, and the wicked shall not be: yea, thou shalt diligently consider his place, and it shall not be” (Psalm 37:10). “The wicked shall perish… into smoke shall they consume away” (Psalm 37:20). The day that cometh “shall burn as an oven; and all the proud, yea, and all that do wickedly, shall be stubble”, and “they shall be ashes under the soles of your feet” (Malachi 4:1, 3). “The soul that sinneth, it shall die” (Ezekiel 18:4). And at the end, fire from God out of heaven “devoured them” (Revelation 20:9).

What is granted. These verses say that the wicked do not last. They are among the strongest in the conditionalist case, and they are true statements of what happens to the wicked in the settings they describe.

The reply. The settings are earthly. Psalm 37 is about who shall inherit the land: “the meek shall inherit the earth” (Psalm 37:11), and the wicked “shall not be” in the place that the righteous dwell in. The prophecy of Malachi is of the day of the Lord on Israel’s land, in which the wicked are stubble, and the verse does not say what comes after. Ezekiel 18 answers the proverb of the fathers and the children in the land of Israel (Ezekiel 18:2, 3) and speaks of the death and life of Israelites under the law in their own day. The fire of Revelation 20:9 devours a living host that has surrounded the camp of the saints, and the next verse, with the devil cast into the lake, speaks of what follows. In all five the verb is of what happens to the living in the age in which they live. The volume grants that these passages speak of the end of the wicked on the earth and does not say that they speak of the lake. It says that they cannot be set against the passages that do.

The objections, what is granted and the reply.

Objection	Held by	What is granted	The reply
The words of destruction mean an ending	Fudge; Atkinson (as Peterson reports)	They do in many verses	They also name a loss of a living person; the passage decides (chapters 3 to 5)
Eternal names a result	Atkinson (as Peterson reports); Fudge	It does in Hebrews 9:12; 5:9; 6:2	The persons go into the punishment as into life; the adjective is not carrying the case alone (chapter 6)
The fire and worm consume	Atkinson (as Peterson reports); Fudge	Isaiah 66:24 is a picture of corpses	The Lord casts living persons into the place (chapter 7)
The smoke is a monument	Atkinson (as Peterson reports)	Isaiah 34 and Revelation 19:3 use smoke so	No rest day nor night and the plural statement of torment are not answered (chapter 8)
Endless punishment is unjust	Stott; Pinnock; Wenham	The question is earnest	No verse states the proportion; the Judge does right and the punishment is graded
The soul's immortality is Greek	Pinnock; others, per Saville	The doctrine is not stated in Scripture	The case does not depend on it
The wicked shall be no more	Fudge; Atkinson (as Peterson reports)	The verses say so	They speak of the earth and of the living; they are not set against the lake

9.9 What the objections leave

The writers on the other side have asked real questions and the volume has tried to answer them without making their case weaker than it is. The reader who has followed the replies will see where they come to rest. The words of destruction do not decide the question in either direction. The adjective of duration can be read as a result and also as a state. The picture of the fire and the worm is a picture of corpses in Isaiah and of a casting in the Gospels. The smoke may be a monument. What remains, when all of this is granted, is the statement of Revelation about persons who are tormented, who have no rest day nor night, and whose plural statement of torment at Revelation 20:10 takes in the beast and the false prophet cast in a thousand years

before. The volume holds that this remains because it is in the text, and that nothing in the objections has removed it.

What the volume takes from the chapter

- Five writers who hold that the lost cease to exist are named, and three who answer them, with a survey of the debate; modern writers are quoted only where their words were read in a free full text.
- The objection from the words of destruction is granted in part: the words describe an ending in many verses; they also describe the loss of persons who live.
- The objection from the word eternal is granted in part: the adjective can name a result; the persons go into the punishment as into life.
- The objections from the fire and the worm and from the smoke are granted at the points where the Old Testament uses the images of a finished ruin, and answered from the Lord's use of the picture and from the sentences about persons in Revelation.
- The objection from justice is answered from what Scripture says of the Judge and of the grading of judgment, and not from a rule of proportion that Scripture does not state.
- The objection from the earthly judgments of the wicked is answered by the settings of the passages, which speak of the living on the earth.

Conclusion

Scripture uses the words of death and destruction both of an ending and of a ruin that remains, and no one of them settles what becomes of the lost. The Lord tells the Twelve that God is able to destroy soul and body in hell, and Paul calls the end of the enemies of the cross destruction. Paul says that those who know not God shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord, an irreversible penalty set against the rest and glory of the saints, whether the preposition names exclusion or source. The Lord sets one adjective on the punishment and on the life, speaks of a fire that is not quenched and a worm that dieth not, and places wailing and gnashing of teeth at the furnace into which the wicked are cast. Revelation says that the worshippers of the beast are tormented in the presence of the Lamb and have no rest day nor night, that the beast and the false prophet were cast alive into the lake of fire, that the devil is cast in a thousand years later, and that the plural statement of torment, day and night for ever and ever, takes in all three. It calls the lake the second death, and in the same book the dead exist, stand and are judged. The passages that say the wicked shall be no more speak of the earth and of the living. Taken together, each in its own setting, the passages on final judgment describe a punishment that is irreversible and enduring and that persons undergo, and none of them states that the persons cease to exist. Any reading that adds a ceasing, or an endless awareness where no verse says it, goes beyond what the text states.

The position in one table.

Question	What the passages state	Chief passages
What do the words of destruction and death mean?	An ending in some verses; the loss or ruin of a person who remains in others; the passage decides	Gen 7:23; Luke 15:24; 1 Cor 5:5
What does the Lord say God is able to do?	Destroy soul and body in hell; after the killing, cast into hell	Matt 10:28; Luke 12:5
What is the penalty in 2 Thessalonians 1?	Everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord, set against the saints' rest	2 Thess 1:6–10
What does the adjective do?	It stands on the punishment and on the life; it can name a lasting result and the persons go into it	Matt 25:46; Dan 12:2; Jude 7
What are the fire and the worm?	A picture of corpses in Isaiah; a place into which a living man is cast in Mark	Isa 66:24; Mark 9:43–48
What is said of the lost in Revelation?	They are tormented and have no rest day nor night; the plural statement of torment at 20:10 takes in the beast and the false prophet cast in a thousand years before	Rev 14:9–11; 19:20; 20:10
What is the second death?	The lake of fire; in the book the dead exist, stand and are judged	Rev 20:12–15; 21:8
Who stands at the great white throne?	The dead, small and great; drawn from the sequence as the rest of the dead; the thousand-year question left open	Rev 20:5, 11–15
What do the passages that say the wicked shall be no more speak of?	The earth and the living, in the settings of Israel	Ps 37:10, 20; Mal 4:1–3; Ezek 18:4

Appendix A. The Passages at a Glance

Each passage the chapters turn on, who is addressed, and what it states.

Passage	Who is addressed	What it states
Matthew 10:28; Luke 12:4, 5	The Twelve on their mission to Israel; the Lord's disciples	God is able to destroy soul and body in hell; after the killing He hath power to cast into hell
Philippians 3:18, 19	The saints at Philippi, of others	The end of the enemies of the cross is destruction
2 Thessalonians 1:6–10	The church of the Thessalonians	Those who know not God shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord
Matthew 25:41, 46	The disciples, in the Olivet Discourse	Everlasting fire; everlasting punishment and life eternal
Daniel 12:2	Daniel, of his people	Some awake to everlasting life and some to shame and everlasting contempt
Jude 7	Them that are sanctified by God the Father	Sodom and Gomorrha suffer the vengeance of eternal fire
Mark 9:43–48	The Twelve at Capernaum	Cast into hell, into the fire that never shall be quenched, where their worm dieth not
Isaiah 66:24	Israel, in the new heavens and new earth	The carcases of the transgressors, their worm shall not die, neither shall their fire be quenched
Revelation 14:9–11	The seven churches, of those who worship the beast	They are tormented; the smoke of their torment ascends; they have no rest day nor night
Revelation 19:20; 20:10	The seven churches, of the beast, the false prophet and the devil	Cast alive into the lake; the devil cast in later; a plural statement of torment day and night for ever and ever
Revelation 20:11–15; 21:8	The seven churches, of the dead	Judged by works; the book of life; the lake is the second death

Appendix B. The Key Passages in Full

The passages on which the volume turns are given here in full, so that a reader can test the argument against the whole text and not only against the verses quoted in the chapters. Verse numbers are in bold. A row of dots marks a gap between verses.

B.1 Daniel 12:1–3

1 And at that time shall Michael stand up, the great prince which standeth for the children of thy people: and there shall be a time of trouble, such as never was since there was a nation even to that same time: and at that time thy people shall be delivered, every one that shall be found written in the book. **2** And many of them that sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt. **3** And they that be wise shall shine as the brightness of the firmament; and they that turn many to righteousness as the stars for ever and ever.

B.2 Isaiah 66:22–24

22 For as the new heavens and the new earth, which I will make, shall remain before me, saith the LORD, so shall your seed and your name remain. **23** And it shall come to pass, that from one new moon to another, and from one sabbath to another, shall all flesh come to worship before me, saith the LORD. **24** And they shall go forth, and look upon the carcases of the men that have transgressed against me: for their worm shall not die, neither shall their fire be quenched; and they shall be an abhorring unto all flesh.

B.3 Matthew 10:5–8, 16–23, 26–33

5 These twelve Jesus sent forth, and commanded them, saying, Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: **6** But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. **7** And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand. **8** Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out devils: freely ye have received, freely give. … **16** Behold, I send you forth as sheep in the midst of wolves: be ye therefore wise as serpents, and harmless as doves. **17** But beware of men: for they will deliver you up to the councils, and they will scourge you in their synagogues; **18** And ye shall be brought before governors and kings for my sake, for a testimony against them and the Gentiles. **19** But when they deliver you up, take no thought how or what ye shall speak: for it shall be given you in that same hour what ye shall speak. **20** For it is not ye that speak, but the Spirit of your Father which speaketh in you. **21** And the brother shall deliver up the brother to death, and the father the child: and the children shall rise up against their parents, and cause them to be put to death. **22** And ye shall be hated of all men for my name's sake: but he that endureth to the end shall be saved. **23** But when they persecute you in this city, flee ye into another: for verily I say unto you, Ye shall not have gone over the cities of Israel, till the Son of man be come. … **26** Fear them not therefore: for there is nothing covered, that shall not be revealed; and hid, that shall not be known. **27** What I tell you in darkness, that speak ye in light: and what ye hear in the ear, that preach ye upon the housetops. **28** And fear not them which kill the body, but are not able to kill the soul: but rather fear him which is able to destroy both soul and body in hell. **29** Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without

your Father. **30** But the very hairs of your head are all numbered. **31** Fear ye not therefore, ye are of more value than many sparrows. **32** Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven. **33** But whosoever shall deny me before men, him will I also deny before my Father which is in heaven.

B.4 Luke 12:1–5

1 In the mean time, when there were gathered together an innumerable multitude of people, insomuch that they trode one upon another, he began to say unto his disciples first of all, Beware ye of the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy. **2** For there is nothing covered, that shall not be revealed; neither hid, that shall not be known. **3** Therefore whatsoever ye have spoken in darkness shall be heard in the light; and that which ye have spoken in the ear in closets shall be proclaimed upon the housetops. **4** And I say unto you my friends, Be not afraid of them that kill the body, and after that have no more that they can do. **5** But I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear: Fear him, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear him.

B.5 Mark 9:42–50

42 And whosoever shall offend one of these little ones that believe in me, it is better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck, and he were cast into the sea. **43** And if thy hand offend thee, cut it off: it is better for thee to enter into life maimed, than having two hands to go into hell, into the fire that never shall be quenched: **44** Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched. **45** And if thy foot offend thee, cut it off: it is better for thee to enter halt into life, than having two feet to be cast into hell, into the fire that never shall be quenched: **46** Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched. **47** And if thine eye offend thee, pluck it out: it is better for thee to enter into the kingdom of God with one eye, than having two eyes to be cast into hell fire: **48** Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched. **49** For every one shall be salted with fire, and every sacrifice shall be salted with salt. **50** Salt is good: but if the salt have lost his saltness, wherewith will ye season it? Have salt in yourselves, and have peace one with another.

B.6 Matthew 25:31–46

31 When the Son of man shall come in his glory, and all the holy angels with him, then shall he sit upon the throne of his glory: **32** And before him shall be gathered all nations: and he shall separate them one from another, as a shepherd divideth his sheep from the goats: **33** And he shall set the sheep on his right hand, but the goats on the left. **34** Then shall the King say unto them on his right hand, Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world: **35** For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in: **36** Naked, and ye clothed me: I was sick, and ye visited me: I was in prison, and ye came unto me. **37** Then shall the righteous answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, and fed thee? or thirsty, and gave thee drink? **38** When saw we thee a stranger, and took thee in? or naked, and clothed thee? **39** Or when saw we thee sick, or in prison, and came unto thee? **40** And the King shall answer and say unto them, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me. **41** Then shall he say also unto them on the left hand, Depart from me, ye cursed, into everlasting fire, prepared for the devil and his angels: **42** For I was an hungred, and ye gave me no meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me no drink: **43** I was a stranger, and ye took me

not in: naked, and ye clothed me not: sick, and in prison, and ye visited me not. **44** Then shall they also answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, or athirst, or a stranger, or naked, or sick, or in prison, and did not minister unto thee? **45** Then shall he answer them, saying, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye did it not to one of the least of these, ye did it not to me. **46** And these shall go away into everlasting punishment: but the righteous into life eternal.

B.7 Philippians 3:17–21

17 Brethren, be followers together of me, and mark them which walk so as ye have us for an ensample. **18** (For many walk, of whom I have told you often, and now tell you even weeping, that they are the enemies of the cross of Christ: **19** Whose end is destruction, whose God is their belly, and whose glory is in their shame, who mind earthly things.) **20** For our conversation is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Saviour, the Lord Jesus Christ: **21** Who shall change our vile body, that it may be fashioned like unto his glorious body, according to the working whereby he is able even to subdue all things unto himself.

B.8 2 Thessalonians 1:3–12

3 We are bound to thank God always for you, brethren, as it is meet, because that your faith groweth exceedingly, and the charity of every one of you all toward each other aboundeth; **4** So that we ourselves glory in you in the churches of God for your patience and faith in all your persecutions and tribulations that ye endure: **5** Which is a manifest token of the righteous judgment of God, that ye may be counted worthy of the kingdom of God, for which ye also suffer: **6** Seeing it is a righteous thing with God to recompense tribulation to them that trouble you; **7** And to you who are troubled rest with us, when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels, **8** In flaming fire taking vengeance on them that know not God, and that obey not the gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ: **9** Who shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord, and from the glory of his power; **10** When he shall come to be glorified in his saints, and to be admired in all them that believe (because our testimony among you was believed) in that day. **11** Wherefore also we pray always for you, that our God would count you worthy of this calling, and fulfil all the good pleasure of his goodness, and the work of faith with power: **12** That the name of our Lord Jesus Christ may be glorified in you, and ye in him, according to the grace of our God and the Lord Jesus Christ.

B.9 Jude 1:5–7, 13

5 I will therefore put you in remembrance, though ye once knew this, how that the Lord, having saved the people out of the land of Egypt, afterward destroyed them that believed not. **6** And the angels which kept not their first estate, but left their own habitation, he hath reserved in everlasting chains under darkness unto the judgment of the great day. **7** Even as Sodom and Gomorrha, and the cities about them in like manner, giving themselves over to fornication, and going after strange flesh, are set forth for an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire. … **13** Raging waves of the sea, foaming out their own shame; wandering stars, to whom is reserved the blackness of darkness for ever.

B.10 Revelation 14:6–13

6 And I saw another angel fly in the midst of heaven, having the everlasting gospel to preach unto them that dwell on the earth, and to every nation, and kindred, and

tongue, and people, **7** Saying with a loud voice, Fear God, and give glory to him; for the hour of his judgment is come: and worship him that made heaven, and earth, and the sea, and the fountains of waters. **8** And there followed another angel, saying, Babylon is fallen, is fallen, that great city, because she made all nations drink of the wine of the wrath of her fornication. **9** And the third angel followed them, saying with a loud voice, If any man worship the beast and his image, and receive his mark in his forehead, or in his hand, **10** The same shall drink of the wine of the wrath of God, which is poured out without mixture into the cup of his indignation; and he shall be tormented with fire and brimstone in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb: **11** And the smoke of their torment ascendeth up for ever and ever: and they have no rest day nor night, who worship the beast and his image, and whosoever receiveth the mark of his name. **12** Here is the patience of the saints: here are they that keep the commandments of God, and the faith of Jesus. **13** And I heard a voice from heaven saying unto me, Write, Blessed are the dead which die in the Lord from henceforth: Yea, saith the Spirit, that they may rest from their labours; and their works do follow them.

B.11 Revelation 19:11–21

11 And I saw heaven opened, and behold a white horse; and he that sat upon him was called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he doth judge and make war. **12** His eyes were as a flame of fire, and on his head were many crowns; and he had a name written, that no man knew, but he himself. **13** And he was clothed with a vesture dipped in blood: and his name is called The Word of God. **14** And the armies which were in heaven followed him upon white horses, clothed in fine linen, white and clean. **15** And out of his mouth goeth a sharp sword, that with it he should smite the nations: and he shall rule them with a rod of iron: and he treadeth the winepress of the fierceness and wrath of Almighty God. **16** And he hath on his vesture and on his thigh a name written, KING OF KINGS, AND LORD OF LORDS. **17** And I saw an angel standing in the sun; and he cried with a loud voice, saying to all the fowls that fly in the midst of heaven, Come and gather yourselves together unto the supper of the great God; **18** That ye may eat the flesh of kings, and the flesh of captains, and the flesh of mighty men, and the flesh of horses, and of them that sit on them, and the flesh of all men, both free and bond, both small and great. **19** And I saw the beast, and the kings of the earth, and their armies, gathered together to make war against him that sat on the horse, and against his army. **20** And the beast was taken, and with him the false prophet that wrought miracles before him, with which he deceived them that had received the mark of the beast, and them that worshipped his image. These both were cast alive into a lake of fire burning with brimstone. **21** And the remnant were slain with the sword of him that sat upon the horse, which sword proceeded out of his mouth: and all the fowls were filled with their flesh.

B.12 Revelation 20:1–15

1 And I saw an angel come down from heaven, having the key of the bottomless pit and a great chain in his hand. **2** And he laid hold on the dragon, that old serpent, which is the Devil, and Satan, and bound him a thousand years, **3** And cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up, and set a seal upon him, that he should deceive the nations no more, till the thousand years should be fulfilled: and after that he must be loosed a little season. **4** And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given unto them: and I saw the souls of them that were beheaded for the witness

of Jesus, and for the word of God, and which had not worshipped the beast, neither his image, neither had received his mark upon their foreheads, or in their hands; and they lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years. **5** But the rest of the dead lived not again until the thousand years were finished. This is the first resurrection. **6** Blessed and holy is he that hath part in the first resurrection: on such the second death hath no power, but they shall be priests of God and of Christ, and shall reign with him a thousand years. **7** And when the thousand years are expired, Satan shall be loosed out of his prison, **8** And shall go out to deceive the nations which are in the four quarters of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them together to battle: the number of whom is as the sand of the sea. **9** And they went up on the breadth of the earth, and compassed the camp of the saints about, and the beloved city: and fire came down from God out of heaven, and devoured them. **10** And the devil that deceived them was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone, where the beast and the false prophet are, and shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever. **11** And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away; and there was found no place for them. **12** And I saw the dead, small and great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books, according to their works. **13** And the sea gave up the dead which were in it; and death and hell delivered up the dead which were in them: and they were judged every man according to their works. **14** And death and hell were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death. **15** And whosoever was not found written in the book of life was cast into the lake of fire.

B.13 Revelation 21:1–8

1 And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away; and there was no more sea. **2** And I John saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down from God out of heaven, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. **3** And I heard a great voice out of heaven saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them, and they shall be his people, and God himself shall be with them, and be their God. **4** And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away. **5** And he that sat upon the throne said, Behold, I make all things new. And he said unto me, Write: for these words are true and faithful. **6** And he said unto me, It is done. I am Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the end. I will give unto him that is athirst of the fountain of the water of life freely. **7** He that overcometh shall inherit all things; and I will be his God, and he shall be my son. **8** But the fearful, and unbelieving, and the abominable, and murderers, and whoremongers, and sorcerers, and idolaters, and all liars, shall have their part in the lake which burneth with fire and brimstone: which is the second death.

Appendix C. Where the Passages Are Read

Every passage cited in the chapters, the Preface, the Thesis and the Conclusion, in the order of the Bible, with the pages on which it is read. Each citation is listed as written in the text. The appendices are not indexed. A page number is the number in the footer.

The passages in the order of the Bible.

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Genesis 5:5	ch. 9, p. 39	
Genesis 7:22	ch. 3, pp. 6, 10	
Genesis 7:22, 23	ch. 3, p. 7	
Genesis 7:23	ch. 3, pp. 6, 10; Conclusion, p. 44	
Genesis 18:25	ch. 9, p. 40	
Exodus 10:7	ch. 3, pp. 8, 9, 10	
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Isaiah 2:19	ch. 5, p. 17	
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Isaiah 66:23	ch. 7, p. 24	In full, Appendix B
Isaiah 66:24	ch. 6, p. 20; ch. 7, pp. 24, 25, 27, 28; ch. 9, pp. 39, 42; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
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Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
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Ezekiel 20:47	ch. 7, pp. 24, 25, 28; ch. 9, p. 39	
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Daniel 12:2	ch. 6, pp. 18, 20, 22; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
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Matthew 5:22	ch. 7, p. 26	
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Matthew 8:12	ch. 7, p. 27	
Matthew 9:17	ch. 3, pp. 8, 9, 10	
Matthew 10:5, 6	ch. 4, p. 11	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 10:6	ch. 3, pp. 7, 9, 10	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 10:6, 7	ch. 2, p. 5	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 10:7	ch. 4, p. 11	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 10:8	ch. 4, p. 11	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 10:15	ch. 4, p. 11	
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Matthew 10:28	ch. 2, p. 4; ch. 4, pp. 11, 12, 13, 14; ch. 5, p. 16; ch. 7, p. 26; ch. 9, pp. 38, 41; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 11:22	ch. 8, p. 34	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
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Matthew 25:46	ch. 2, p. 4; ch. 6, pp. 19, 20, 22; ch. 9, p. 39; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
Matthew 26:8	ch. 3, p. 8; ch. 4, p. 13	
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Mark 9:43–48	ch. 7, pp. 27, 28; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
Mark 9:48	ch. 7, pp. 23, 25; ch. 9, p. 39	In full, Appendix B
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Luke 12:5	ch. 4, pp. 11, 12, 14; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
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Luke 19:10	ch. 3, pp. 8, 10	
John 3:36	ch. 6, p. 22	
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Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
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2 Thessalonians 1:5	ch. 5, p. 15	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:6	ch. 5, p. 15	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:6–10	ch. 5, p. 15; Conclusion, p. 44	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:7	ch. 5, p. 15	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:8	ch. 5, pp. 15, 17	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:9	ch. 2, pp. 4, 5; ch. 5, p. 16	In full, Appendix B
2 Thessalonians 1:10	ch. 5, p. 16	In full, Appendix B
1 Timothy 6:9	ch. 5, p. 16	
Hebrews 5:9	ch. 6, p. 19; ch. 9, pp. 39, 42	
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Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
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Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
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Revelation 20:15	ch. 8, pp. 32, 36	In full, Appendix B
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Revelation 21:8	ch. 2, p. 5; ch. 8, pp. 32, 33, 34	In full, Appendix B
Revelation 21:24	ch. 8, p. 36	
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